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**The relationship between effective team leadership and evolving work
models in a small financial services company.**

A study of Company X.

Claudio Mares

Declaration

In presenting this dissertation for assessment I, Claudio Mares, declare that it is a final copy including any last revisions. I also declare that it is entirely the result of my own work other than where sources are explicitly acknowledged and referenced within the body of the text. This dissertation has not been previously submitted, in whole or in substantial part, for any degree at this or any other institution.

It is being submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of MBA Leadership and Management at York St. John University, United Kingdom.

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Abstract

This research investigated team leadership in a case study organisation, Company X, a financial services company with fifteen staff, that quickly transitioned from office-based to virtual to hybrid working during the Covid-19 pandemic. The findings were analysed in relation to a range of theories on team leadership and recommendations were made on how virtual and hybrid team leadership could be improved. Through this process the research looked at what the attributes of effective team leadership in virtual and hybrid teams may be, how leadership influences effective team working in those scenarios, and how these are observed in practice.

The reviewed literature included recently published journal articles and textbooks published mainly in the last two decades by scholars in the field of team leadership and behavioural studies. Information on the interactions and processes of teams at Company X was collected and analysed through the method of qualitative analysis by way of ten semi-structured interviews and thematic analysis. Additionally, secondary qualitative and limited quantitative data was collected by analysing two staff surveys on hybrid working conducted at Company X.

The data analysis from the fieldwork combined with gathered information from the literature review provided material for recommendations on how virtual and hybrid team leadership at the case study organisation could be improved. The research showed that effective team leaders at Company X kept their teams focused on tasks and provided structure to them, they provided them with support to be as effective as possible, and they helped, developed, and connected with people; all of which was underpinned by good communication.

Specific areas of improvement in virtual and hybrid team leadership at Company X were identified as bringing consistency into team leadership across the organisation, maximising the opportunities that hybrid working offers, and developing team leadership skills for the new way of working.

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1. Introduction

The ongoing global pandemic has forced Company X, like most other traditionally office-based companies, to quickly alter where their staff work and how they interact. This fundamental change has also meant that team leaders have had to adapt their leadership style to ensure their now virtual or hybrid teams continue to perform effectively (Gratton, 2021).

Company X is a small financial services company based in the City of London. Its fifteen staff provide insurance products and services to corporate clients globally. Whilst the pandemic has had no impact on the turnover of the business, how and where the staff work has changed. Only two of the fifteen staff were regular home-based workers before the pandemic started, whereas from March 2020 until the summer of 2021 100% of staff were working from home. Since the summer of 2021, the company has adopted a hybrid working model for all its London-based staff.

The sudden switch of working modes due to the pandemic created some unique challenges for leaders and the work force. For Company X and many other companies, the new virtual working arrangements were not planned, the IT communication technology was untested, and the switch to home working was forced by government and circumstances (CIPD, 2020). The total lack of face-to face social interactions with people outside of one's household due to national lockdowns was also unique. Furthermore, childcare suddenly had to be reimagined as most schools and nurseries remained shut for long periods of time affecting working parents (CIPD, 2020). Additionally, according to a recent McKinsey study, employees are also nervous about the future, fuelled by employers' lack of clear vision of post-pandemic work (Alexander *et al.*, 2021).

Established theory on team working and leadership addresses virtuality in teams and its requirements on team leaders (West, 2012). The literature at the time of writing this dissertation, however, does not extensively deal with leaders having to suddenly change from leading their teams face-to-face to virtually to a situation where both engagement models are in place simultaneously. Furthermore, the lack of face-to-face social interactions due to lockdowns coupled with virtual and hybrid work models has not been widely discussed in published literature at the time of carrying out this research.

The illustrated challenges for team leaders and staff during the pandemic, and as Company X transitions into a new post-pandemic work model, form the basis for this research project. The research is designed to provide best practices for team leadership to support the organisation, the

team leaders, and staff in the new hybrid work model. In addition, the researcher, one of Company X's team leaders and member of the Company's leadership team, ultimately would like to embrace these best practices, further build on them, and become an ambassador of hybrid working in the insurance world of the City of London.

1.1 Research question and research objectives

To achieve the above goals, this research explores how leaders can optimise how they lead and support their teams through the transition of work engagement models. The research question and research objectives of this project have therefore been developed as follows:

Research Question:

What makes for effective team leadership during the evolution from office-based to virtual to hybrid working in a case study organisation?

Research objectives:

1. Literature review on team leadership and team leadership in virtual and hybrid work environments.
2. Collect information on how teams are led from leaders' and followers' perspectives, assemble information on differences (if any) between virtual, office-based, and hybrid scenarios from leaders' and followers' perspectives.
3. Analysis of this information to identify what constitutes effective team leadership, indicate if there are differences between virtual, office-based, or hybrid scenarios and how these relate to published literature on team working and team leadership in a virtual, office-based, or hybrid context.
4. Recommend actions that could be taken to maximise the positive attributes of team leadership across the virtual and hybrid scenarios with a focus on the hybrid mode, while limiting negative influencing factors.

1.2 Methodology

As a case study, this research looks at how team leadership is practised in various work modes within Company X (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2016). The researcher is mainly conducting exploratory research according to Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill (2016) to establish if there are similarities or differences in how leadership is perceived in the various work engagement modes.

A qualitative approach by way of semi-structured interviews of Company X's team leaders and team members is chosen as the primary data collection method. This approach allows for collection of ample data with a focus on respondents' perspectives on team leadership and work modes; and it can maximise data collection linked to the respondents' familiarity with the situation (Ghauri, Gronhaug and Strange, 2020).

The research is structured as cross-sectional research to provide a snapshot of the situation at a given time; a longitudinal study is not deemed practical given the limited time available (Robson and McCartan, 2016).

Secondary data is collected through analysis of Company X's HR questionnaires on staff satisfaction with the new hybrid mode.

1.3 Overview of the structure of the dissertation

The overall structure of the paper takes the form of seven sections, including this introduction.

Section two begins with laying out the various team leadership theories and looks at how various scholars describe effective team working, team leadership, leadership of virtual teams, and leadership of hybrid teams.

Section three is concerned with the research methodology and reviews the research philosophy and strategy, including methods, sampling, and ethics.

Section four covers the findings of the research and presents key themes and quotations emerging from the qualitative data collection and their relevance in relation to the research.

Section five provides a discussion of the key findings and how they relate to published ideas.

Section six highlights key conclusions from the research and links back to the research question and objectives.

The seventh and final section provides a reflection on the process of undertaking the dissertation. It looks at skills applied during the process, personal development required during the process and for future projects.

2. Literature review

This literature review looks at how different scholars describe team working, team leadership, and leadership of virtual and hybrid teams from different perspectives.

Many theories expressing varying views on effective team leadership exist. Important general leadership theories, such as transformational leadership theories, are also described as applicable to team leadership. Dionne *et al.* (2004) for instance, found in their study that transformational leadership improves team performance by boosting communication, resolving conflict, and creating a feeling of being unified. One might therefore conclude that the idea of individuals being aligned to achieve the objectives of the organisation or a greater good led by an inspirational leader apply also to team leadership scenarios (Dionne *et al.*, 2004).

Transactional leadership, or management, is argued by some to be an important skill to be exhibited in combination with transformational leadership (Kotter, 1990; Bass and Riggio, 2006). However, some scholars regard the focus on dyadic relationships in both of these theories as a problem for their practical application (Yukl, 1999).

Before looking at the leadership of teams in more detail, this review briefly covers published views on what contributes to team effectiveness.

2.1 Effective teams

Most researchers describe effective teams as having clear roles and goals that are underpinned by good communication and relationships (Salas, Sims and Burke, 2005; Gratton and Erickson, 2007; Senior and Swailes, 2007). Lencioni (2011) adds that effective teams are also concentrated on results and make sure that team members and the team collectively are answerable to accomplishing those results.

Hackman (2002) takes a different approach and views a team's effectiveness primarily driven by how the team completes its tasks whilst relying on a limited amount of norms to achieve this. West (2012) and Wheelan (2016) on the contrary, stress the importance of processes that nurture supportive behaviour and collaboration as key ingredients for good team working.

Effective teams are largely characterised by an optimal team composition and have gone through stages of development to achieve effectiveness (Wheelan, 2016). It is reported that teams that

reach this level of development have done so by establishing effective communication norms built on trust and a discrete team culture (Senior and Swailes, 2007; Wheelan, 2016).

Clarity in roles within the team as well as in how team goals are aligned with those of the wider organisation are also widely reported to contribute to the effectiveness of a team (West, 2012; Wheelan, 2016). In addition, mutual understanding of the team's purpose and direction promotes shared mental models that allow for team members to take charge of some leadership tasks (Tannenbaum and Salas, 2020). Furthermore, the extent to which the organisation supports the team, such as through providing necessary resources, also impacts the success of the team.

It is possible to conclude that team effectiveness is influenced by good communications norms that support collaboration, team cohesion, and how well the team is aligned with the wider organisation.

The varying influence of diversity on a team's effectiveness is widely discussed in the literature. According to Holtzman and Anderberg (2011), diverse teams with team members that are well aligned display higher levels of productivity. West (2012) is in agreement but points out that diverse teams in early stages of development may struggle with effectiveness. Others regard diversity in teams generally as a key factor enhancing efficiency and success (Mello and Ruckes, 2006; Kline, 2011).

Team effectiveness is also impacted by a team's decision-making processes. Whilst Buchanan and Huczynski (2019) regard it as crucial for a team to engage in conflict around its tasks in order for the team to fully endorse decisions, others encourage teams to collaborate harmoniously and really listen to each other (Kline, 2011). A team that is too harmonious though can lead to groupthink thus reducing effectiveness in how it operates (Super, 2020). The previously mentioned diversity in a team can help counter this potential challenge by allowing for constructive discussions that lead to unified decisions (Tannenbaum and Salas, 2020). On balance the evidence suggests that effective teams have processes in place that allow for decision-making based on good communication.

2.2 Effective team leadership

A number of established team leadership theories exists (Zaccaro, Rittman and Marks, 2001; Hackman, 2002; Day, Gronn and Salas, 2004). They discuss how team leaders have an impact on

their teams’ processes thereby supporting their team members in performing their tasks and collaborating effectively.

Good team leaders connect with their teams and contribute to their teams’ successes by way of enabling innovation, creativity, and team learning (Wheelan, 2016; Super, 2020). They also ensure their team members keep developing and provide them with the necessary mentoring, coaching, and training (Gratton and Erickson, 2007). West (2012) concurs and further specifies that team leaders should ensure all team members know how they individually contribute towards team goals. An important task of team leaders is therefore to keep their teams focused on personal development and connected with team objectives.

Others argue that indeed a key function of a team leader is to promote an inclusive environment where diverse concepts are valued (Super, 2020). There is however, some consensus amongst scholars on effective team leaders to positively affect how solid a team is, how conflicts within the team are managed, and how the team culture is shaped (West, 2012; Wheelan, 2016; Buchanan and Huczynski, 2019).

Out of the myriad of established team leadership theories, the models by Katzenbach and Smith (2015) (Table 2.1) and Kogler Hill (2019) (Figure 2.1) have been chosen to illustrate some differing ideas.

Table 2.1, Six things necessary for good team leadership, based on Katzenbach and Smith (2015)

1. Keep the purpose, goals, and approach relevant and meaningful
2. Build commitment and confidence
3. Strengthen the mix and level of skills
4. Manage relationships with outsiders, including removing obstacles
5. Create opportunities for others
6. Do real work

Figure 2.1, The Hill model for team leadership (Kogler Hill, 2019)



According to Kogler Hill (2019), the leader sits outside the team, analyses what is happening, and keeps their interventions to a minimum. Katzenbach and Smith (2015) however, consider the team leader to be embedded into the team. Yet, both agree that a team leader is an ambassador of their team to the outside world and see it at their responsibility to remove any obstacles that may hinder their team's success. Both also suggest a team leader needs to make sure the required skills are present by structuring the team accordingly and if needed adding to it.

The model by Katzenbach and Smith (2015) is rather practical and describes how leaders can effectively do their jobs by illustrating possible actions and ways of tackling challenges. In contrast, the model Kogler Hill (2019) is quite abstract and may not be suitable for team leaders who need hands-on guidance on how to deal with day-to-day situations. However, the model can be a useful decision matrix tool that helps a leader with making crucial initial decisions on whether to, and how to, interact with the team (Kogler Hill, 2019). In summary, a combination of elements from both models could help leaders stay focused and keep their actions in context.

Team leaders arguably have a big impact on team norms (Wheelan, 2016). Super (2020) observes that the effect changes over time as the team evolves through the various stages of development, with the leader of a more established team taking on the role of facilitator and including the team members in the leadership process. Such shared leadership in teams is also understood to improve problem solving thus making team members feel better connected (Hoch, 2014). It must be recognised though that the Covid-19 pandemic has required a crisis mode leadership approach that may influence team development and norming differently (Caringal-Go *et al.*, 2021).

A team leader's role in enabling and supporting trust is also widely discussed in the literature. Not only is nurturing trust seen as a key enabler of effective team work (Lencioni, 2011), it is also regarded as a critical way for team leaders to strengthen their impact on the team (Newman, Ford and Marshall, 2020).

2.3 Leadership of virtual teams

Leading virtual teams poses some special challenges and requires additional different skills to those leading co-located teams (Hooijberg and Watkins, 2021). Virtual team leaders are required to manage circumstances where their team members are separated by location, sometimes working different hours, and connecting mostly through technology (West, 2012; Buchanan and Huczynski, 2019).

Establishing unity and team culture in virtual teams requires team leaders to shape unique team engagement norms. They encourage team members to communicate amongst each other virtually (Dinh *et al.*, 2021; Gilson *et al.*, 2021; Kirkman and Stoverink, 2021). They also ensure that everyone gets to speak when team meetings are held virtually (Wotapka, 2021). However, Malhotra, Majchrzak and Rosen (2007) argue that team leaders also need to carefully manage asynchronous exchanges between meetings. Additionally, virtual team leaders use technology-based communication to establish a connection between team members' day-to-day work and wider organisational goals (Reyes, Luna and Salas, 2021). It is crucial that team leaders allocate time to support their team members in understanding this link between team and organisational culture and to build trust (Newman and Ford, 2021). It is therefore possible to assume that communication norms in virtual teams need to be carefully developed and maintained to make sure team members feel engaged and the team feels cohesive.

Furthermore, team leaders of virtual teams strengthen team cohesion by providing clear guidance on everyone's role through regular communication (Ferrazzi, 2014; Newman, Ford and Marshall, 2020). This in turn further reinforces team effectiveness (Dinh *et al.*, 2021; Elyousfi, Anand and Dalmasso, 2021; Gilson *et al.*, 2021; Reyes, Luna and Salas, 2021). Liao (2017) suggests in addition, that such actions can promote the formation of shared mental models. Establishing such models is widely regarded as contributing to effective team working and it is the team leader's role to ensure the team's shared understanding of how they all interact remains accurate (Reyes, Luna and Salas, 2021; Tannenbaum *et al.*, 2021). However, for shared mental models to develop successfully in a virtual team, the team needs to grasp the use of communication technology and the team leader must ensure the team is supported in acquiring the required skills (Liao, 2017).

The importance of communication technology features equally in the discussion of conflict management. Whilst it is suggested that virtual teams are more prone to conflict than co-located teams, as long as clarity is established on how conflict is handled, teams can operate effectively (Gilson *et al.*, 2021). Morgan, Paucar-Caceres and Wright (2014) however, whilst agreeing that a clearly defined conflict management process contributes to virtual team effectiveness, see this as no different to how co-located teams operate.

A virtual team leader needs to also be tech-savvy and mindful of communication channel preferences of their team members to ensure effective communication for everyone (Settle-Murphy, 2012). While Liao (2017) emphasises that understanding the team's technical capabilities and training requirement is vital for successful collaboration, others advocate for training in awareness of virtual meeting etiquette (Karl, Peluchette and Aghakhani, 2021). Leaders also help their teams overcome virtual meeting-related practical challenges, such as cameras not being turned on, internet connections being too weak, meetings being scheduled back-to-back and contributing to stress (Karl, Peluchette and Aghakhani, 2021).

On balance, the evidence suggests that the use of technology represents a difference in how a team leader establishes cohesion, shared understanding, and conflict management in a virtual team compared to a co-located team leader. Team leaders need to help their teams work with communication technology.

Leading virtual teams brings further distinctive challenges, some of which were created by the pandemic. Leaders of virtual teams need to methodically create opportunities for interaction with the team and carefully think about the complexity in tasks the team needs to tackle and whether

synchronous or asynchronous communication is more appropriate to collaborate on those (Bell and Kozlowski, 2002). Kayworth and Leidner (2002) add that another important challenge for virtual team leaders lies in the need to clearly define everyone's role while remaining approachable and showing empathy.

There is agreement on the need to communicate regularly to develop team members and overcome the challenge of creating a unique culture and building trust in the team (Bell and Kozlowski, 2002; Kayworth and Leidner, 2002; Chamakiotis, Panteli and Davison, 2021). Virtual team coaching and mentoring are also seen as important ways of developing team members (Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato, 2021; Kirkman and Stoverink, 2021). Dinh *et al.* (2021) add that leaders should also check in regularly to establish how well team members' development is going.

The shift to unplanned virtual team working has also meant that work and personal life boundaries have started to become blurred for many people and team leaders' responsibilities have been extended to look after their staff's mental well-being probably more than those leading co-located teams (Chamakiotis, Panteli and Davison, 2021). The issue of work-life boundaries has been aggravated by the fact that, unlike pre-pandemic, whole families have been in lockdown where working and living has been confined to people's homes (Chamakiotis, Panteli and Davison, 2021).

Furthermore, a leader of a virtual team, similarly to a co-located team leader, encourages trust building in their team by promoting open communication and encouraging feedback (Gilson *et al.*, 2015). Encouraging social interactions and sharing personal details is regarded by some scholars as the way forward (Zander, Zettinig and Mäkelä, 2013; Gilson *et al.*, 2021). Whilst some argue that such interactions, based on electronic communications, need to occur regularly and be actively encouraged by team leaders (Malhotra, Majchrzak and Rosen, 2007), others suggest introducing formal organisational procedures to promote ways of building trust (Ford, Piccolo and Ford, 2017).

It is possible to conclude that a virtual team leader's effectiveness is influenced by how they communicate with their team, how tuned into their team members' situations they are, and how well they structure the team's tasks and roles to match the unique challenges virtual working poses.

2.4 Team leadership in a hybrid work model

A unique challenge for leaders of hybrid teams as opposed to virtual and co-located team leaders is that they continually have to adapt how they engage with their teams depending on whether they are co-located or collaborating virtually (Hooijberg and Watkins, 2021). The transition from one mode to another can be difficult and keeping the team connected is a key task for team leaders (Reyes, Luna and Salas, 2021). It is as important for team leaders to recognise how much their team appreciates the flexibility hybrid working brings (De Smet *et al.*, 2021). Ultimately, for a hybrid team to work together effectively, they should experience the continuous transition from engaging virtually to face-to-face as seamlessly as possible (Dixon and Panteli, 2010). It may be concluded that a hybrid team leader's adaptability and focus on the requirement of the team can enhance the effectiveness of a hybrid team.

Providing a smooth transition between virtual and office-based working also seeps into the discussion of setting and measuring team goals. In order to measure team or team member success while in virtual mode, Carroll and Conboy (2020) argue that leaders should pay attention to outcomes only and ignore how the output was achieved. Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato (2021) agree and argue that objectives should also reflect the freedom hybrid working brings and inspire staff to be more proactive. This way of looking at performance however, does not satisfy employees' need for more informal face-to-face coaching to help them develop how they work (Whillans, Perlow and Turek, 2021). It may be assumed that team leaders should use hybrid team specific output-focused measures coupled with informal face-to-face feedback to nurture and assess team development.

For hybrid team leaders to create effective teams, Gratton (2021) recommends ensuring their teams engage in collaborative tasks in synchronous time either in the office or virtually and tackle tasks that can be done autonomously at any time either in the office or from anywhere. And whilst Hooijberg and Watkins (2021) agree with this task separating, they suggest performing collaborative tasks when engaging face-to-face and routine tasks when working remotely. Chamakiotis, Panteli and Davison (2021) further argue that innovation-focused activities need to be split into tasks that have to be done synchronously, such as brainstorming, and those that can be done asynchronously. It is important that team leaders create communication norms that help with the coordination of this new working practice (Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato, 2021). Furthermore, per a recent McKinsey report, staff productivity can be increased if team leaders check in with them by way of regular, short connections (Alexander *et al.*, 2021). In summary,

these analyses suggest a fundamental review of existing workflows is needed to increase productivity.

Collaboration is required to tackle complex tasks such as developing new ideas or solving complex problems. These tasks often require creativity that occurs when team members cooperate face-to-face and virtual team leaders can have a big impact by designing the new office environment to facilitate such collaboration and trust-building (Fayard, Weeks and Khan, 2021). Although Hooijberg and Watkins (2021) also emphasise the importance of complex tasks to be accomplished when engaging face-to-face with the team leader actively stimulating creativity, they point out that building trust is something that needs to be accomplished when in face-to-face as well as in virtual mode. Having the opportunity to collaborate face-to-face at times is a big advantage of hybrid working compared to pure virtual team working.

There is some consensus amongst scholars that organisations need to invest in team leader development so that the new way of hybrid working runs smoothly (Gratton, 2021; Hooijberg and Watkins, 2021). Providing dedicated training for team leaders communicates to their teams that any new challenges they may encounter are being addressed for them (Ford, Piccolo and Ford, 2017). Just like for virtual teams, tackling technological challenges remains an important area for development also in the hybrid scenario (Chamakiotis, Panteli and Davison, 2021; Dinh *et al.*, 2021). However, on a more general level, training for organisations in the hybrid mode needs to be carefully planned. Whilst some training can be done effectively virtually, more informal knowledge transfer is done more effectively when colleagues are located in the same office (Fayard, Weeks and Khan, 2021).

Encouraging social interactions in hybrid teams brings yet more unique challenges to team leaders. Fayard, Weeks and Khan (2021) view these interactions centred around the office and argue that team leaders should set an example by socialising and encourage their team members to do the same. Impromptu and informal connections are made more easily in the office setup (Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato, 2021). Whilst Whillans, Perlow and Turek (2021) agree that informal interactions in an office environment work better, they actually found in their study that colleagues can get to know each other more intensely on a personal level while connecting virtually one-to-one. However, virtual social interactions as a group are reported to be less effective compared to face-to-face interactions (Whillans, Perlow and Turek, 2021). One may deduce that a hybrid team leader needs to sense what type of interaction works best for their teams and nurture a culture where social interactions are made a priority.

It is too early to say if the current trend of hybrid working will remain the new norm. Currently, it seems employees enjoy the flexibility that this new work model provides but they do not know yet what the ideal future for them looks like whereas employers want their staff back in the office as quickly as possible (De Smet *et al.*, 2021). Conversely, an increase in productivity attributed to hybrid working is reported by leaders (Alexander *et al.*, 2021). Hybrid working that lasts into the future needs to satisfy both the organisation's and employees' needs and wants (Gratton, 2021). Thorough consideration and designing of the new working practices is required (Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato, 2021). Whatever the future, it seems that team leaders' adaptability and relationship with their teams will remain key to success.

2.5 Summary

The reviewed literature has uncovered that whilst general team leadership ideas seem applicable in all scenarios, virtual and hybrid team leaders also require some unique skills.

Team leaders with good communication skills who are focused on developing their teams appear to be effective in any work scenario. Additionally, what also seems to distinguish effective team leaders is their ability to manage conflicts, bring team members together as one cohesive team, and protect the team from the outside world.

Virtual team leaders are faced with the unique challenge of establishing shared mental models without the chance of informal knowledge transfer that is said to happen more easily when people work in the same office.

The roles of virtual and hybrid team leaders appear to share some specific requirements:

- providing more clarity on roles and tasks than leaders of co-located teams
- grasping the use of communications technology to help their teams work effectively
- supporting their teams in maintaining a good work/life balance

Hybrid team leaders are faced with some unique challenges:

- adaptability of leadership style to match virtual/office working
- maximising benefits of flexibility offered by hybrid working

Whilst the way trust is established varies depending on work mode, it seems to underpin all effective team interactions.

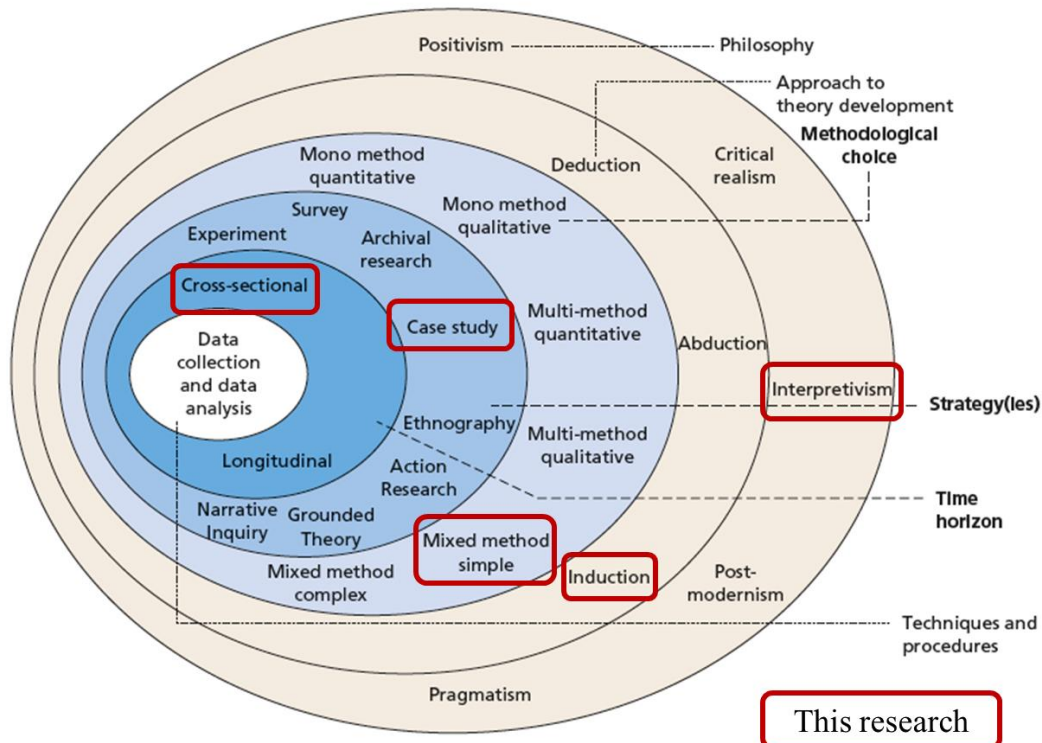
3. Methodology

The purpose of this research is to establish what constitutes effective team leadership as Company X transitions from office-based to virtual to hybrid working. The research also intends to provide best practices for team leadership in the virtual and hybrid scenarios with a focus on the hybrid mode.

The researcher performed mainly exploratory research according to Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill (2016) to establish if there were similarities or differences in how leadership was perceived in the various work engagement modes within a case study organisation.

When formulating the research design the researcher found the “research onion” by Sanders, Lews and Thornnill (2016) helpful. Figure 3.1 provides a visual display of how this research fits into the model and what selections were made with respect to philosophy, theory development, methodology, strategy, and timing. The following paragraphs provide a more detailed description of the choices that were made.

Figure 3.1, The research onion, adapted from Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill (2016)



3.1 Research philosophy

The research assumptions and principles underpinning this project were based on the research philosophy of Interpretivism (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2016; Clark *et al.*, 2021) or Social Constructionism (Easterby-Smith *et al.*, 2018).

The starting point of this research was the question around effective team leadership and how it may or may not change as Company X transitions quickly from an office-based organisation to one where people collaborate virtually and then to a hybrid scenario. In terms of Ontology, the research assumed a relativism approach as staff within Company X would view effective leadership differently and would each experience and describe their version of the truth (Easterby-Smith *et al.*, 2018). With regard to Epistemology, the research followed an Interpretivism approach by focusing on stories told by the research participants and their interpretations of what happened, and by developing new ideas (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2016).

Despite the above position regarding the philosophy, the researcher is also in agreement with the view of Robson and McCartan (2016) that there is no single correct approach and the research question determines the choice for the most suitable research philosophy. The researcher may adopt objectivist and positivist positions in a different research project.

3.2 Research strategy

The research strategy was structured as a case study whereby team leaders and team members of Company X provided detailed accounts of how they exhibited and perceived team leadership at a particular point in time when Company X transitioned through various work modes (Robson and McCartan, 2016). The research was a mixed method simple, with qualitative dominant over quantitative analysis (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2016). Primary data collection was a qualitative study by way of semi-structured interviews. The collection of secondary data by way of analysing Company X's HR satisfaction surveys included some limited quantitative analysis in addition to qualitative analysis.

An inductive research approach was taken towards theory development and was based on the research question and objectives mentioned above with the goal to build theory (Robson and McCartan, 2016).

3.2.1. Information gathering process

Primary data was collected through ten semi-structured interviews. Invitations to participate in the research were sent via email and provided a brief description of the project, they also included a research consent form outlining ethical considerations (see Appendix 1 for a copy of the research consent form that was sent to each potential participant). Eight interviews then took place via Zoom calls and two interviews were conducted face-to-face at Company X's office. The interviews were all recorded, as agreed with the participants.

All interviews took place over four weeks in September 2021. On average, they lasted 58 minutes, with the shortest one lasting 46 minutes and the longest one 73 minutes (see Table 3.1 for more details). The semi-structured interviews with an element of follow-up questions allowed for flexibility in the research as progress was made in the data collection phase throughout the month (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2016). The advantages of this method and alternatives are discussed later in the chapter.

Table 3.1, Interview schedule and duration

Interview number	Date	Duration (minutes, rounded)	
		Team leader	Team member
I.1 (Pilot)	02/09/2021		66
I.2	06/09/2021		56
I.3	09/09/2021	53	
I.4	10/09/2021		57
I.5	10/09/2021	73	
I.6	13/09/2021		56
I.7	14/09/2021		63
I.8	20/09/2021		46
I.9	21/09/2021	65	
I.10	27/09/2021	47	
Average time		60	57
		58 (all interviews)	

This chosen primary data collection instrument required careful planning. The researcher ran a pilot interview early in the month to establish whether the planned timing and questions worked in reality and whether anything had to be adjusted (Robson and McCartan, 2016). The pilot interview confirmed that the allocated time was sufficient to cover all stem questions and that there was enough time for follow-up and probing questions. Following the pilot interview, the participant confirmed that all the questions they had been asked were clear and therefore no changes to the stem questions were made.

The interview guide that was used as a template for the interviews was developed while researching the published literature on the research topic (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2016). It consisted of some common introductory questions for all participants and separate stem and follow-up questions depending on the participant's role as either team leader or team member (see Appendix 2 for the interview guide). Flexibility in the interviews was provided by using open-ended questions leading to explore different areas for different interviewees. Further flexibility was given by the limited number of stem questions allowing for individual follow-up and probing questions. The following table includes some examples of how some of the questions were linked to published theory (Table 3.2).

Table 3.2, Examples of interview questions linked to published theories

Stem questions (and follow-ups):	Published theory link (some examples):
1 What do you regard as the priorities of your role as team leader?	Evidence of “Do real work”? (Katzenbach and Smith, 2015). Team leader role evolving through development stages (Super, 2020).
2 How do you tend to work with the people who report to you?	“Leadership decisions” (Kogler Hill, 2019). “Six things necessary to good team leadership” (Katzenbach and Smith, 2015).
3 How have you communicated with your team since the first lockdown?	Linking daily work to organisational goals (Reyes, Luna and Salas, 2021). Communication norms that ensure everyone is heard (Wotapka, 2021). Establishing shared mental models through effective use of communication technology (Liao, 2017).
4 How have you matched tasks that needed to be tackled to the skills available within the team? Follow-up: Are each team member’s role and contribution clear to everyone in the team? Is the team’s purpose clear to each team member? Is the team aligned with other teams in the organisation?	“Strengthen the mix and level of skills, create opportunities for others” (Katzenbach and Smith, 2015). “Internal leadership actions - tasks” (Kogler Hill, 2019). Clarity in roles and alignment of team goals with organisation (West, 2012; Wheelan, 2016). (Dinh <i>et al.</i> , 2021; Elyousfi, Anand and Dalmasso, 2021; Gilson <i>et al.</i> , 2021; Reyes, Luna and Salas, 2021).
5 Have you done anything to encourage team members to communicate with each other? Follow-up: What makes the team unique? How do you describe the team to the outside world? Have there been social interactions outside work?	“Internal leadership actions – relational, External leadership actions - environmental” (Kogler Hill, 2019). (Dinh <i>et al.</i> , 2021; Gilson <i>et al.</i> , 2021; Kirkman and Stoverink, 2021).
6 How have you measured your team's success during the pandemic?	(Carroll and Conboy, 2020; Birkinshaw, Gudka and D’Amato, 2021; Dinh <i>et al.</i> , 2021; Whillans, Perlow and Turek, 2021).
7 What have been the challenges of working virtually?	Unique virtual team leadership challenges (Chamakiotis, Panteli and Davison, 2021; Dinh <i>et al.</i> , 2021)
8 Have you been able to establish a healthy work/life balance?	Boundaries of work and personal life (Chamakiotis, Panteli and Davison, 2021).

Even though the research primarily consisted of cross-sectional data collection at one point in time (Clark *et al.*, 2021), a longitudinal effect could be achieved through secondary data

collection. Secondary data was collected through investigating Company X's staff responses to two separate HR surveys on employee satisfaction with the new hybrid work model. These questionnaires ran in August 2021 and in October 2021 and covered various aspects of the new work model (see Table 3.3 for the survey questions). Responses to six of the questions were positive/neutral/negative plus free-text, and questions 4, 8, and 9 invited responses in the staff's own words only. The survey in August had 15 responses, the survey in October had 10 responses.

Table 3.3, HR survey questions

1	How are you enjoying your new working pattern?
2	Does your new working pattern help productivity?
3	Do you feel safe, in relation to Covid?
4	What can we do to make you feel more safe?
5	Do you feel that Company X's use of technology supports your productivity?
6	Are you able to schedule your working week with office days focused on collaboration, and WFH days focused on routine tasks and solitary work?
7	Is your manager actively supporting you and promoting this new way of working?
8	If you have encountered any difficulties while getting used to this new way of working, please state what they are.
9	Are there any changes that you would like us to make?

3.2.2. Sample

100% of the invited participants accepted to take part in the research. The participants in this research were ten employees and long-term consultants of Company X, representing 66% of the organisation's population. Four of these people led their own teams and were also part of the leadership team of Company X; the other six were team members (Table 3.4). Since the researcher was one of the team leaders, only four of the five team leaders of Company X could be interviewed. However, all five teams were represented in the research through the participation of team members of all teams. This sample size was within the suggested minimum range of 5-25 for in-depth interviews (Saunders, 2012; Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2016).

Table 3.4, Interviews

Role:	Sample. Number of participants:	% of Company X's population	Company X's population
Team leader:	4	80%	5
Team member:	6	60%	10
Total:	10	66.67%	15

This sampling was based on purposive sampling and aimed to select participants with relevant awareness of the situation while not intending to be representative of the wider population (Creswell and Creswell, 2018; Clark *et al.*, 2021). The researcher knew each participant personally which helped creating rapport during the interviews. However, this meant that the researcher had to be extra vigilant to stay neutral in the way they asked questions.

3.2.3. How the information was analysed

A thematic analysis of the collected primary data was performed (Braun and Clarke, 2006). Familiarisation with that data started by transcribing each interview recording word-for-word using NVivo Transcription. An average of 3 hours per interview was spent listening to the audio files and correcting and finalising the initial automated transcriptions.

The transcripts were printed, and initial codes were generated with pen and paper. At the same time, computer-aided analysis was initiated by learning how to use a CAQDAS software package called NVivo. CAQDAS software was chosen because of its core features of facilitating re-coding and visualisation of data (Creswell and Creswell, 2018; Easterby-Smith *et al.*, 2018). This specific product was chosen following a review of available options and based on positive feedback received from other students. Analysing data first on hardcopies followed by software was an approach suggested by some (Easterby-Smith *et al.*, 2018).

The initially developed codes were transferred to NVivo. Further reading of the transcripts and listening to the audio recordings led to more codes being generated and themes started to emerge, which were grouped into wider ideas and ultimately linked into published theories on team

leadership (Braun and Clarke, 2013). The codes and themes were exported from NVivo into Microsoft Word and are discussed in the next chapter.

Content analysis by way of counting similarity in respondents' answers was also performed (Easterby-Smith et al., 2018). In terms of the primary data analysis, NVivo was used to establish how often codes appeared in the interviews. The researcher also investigated how many people provided a theme and how many themes were established in the research. In terms of the secondary data analysis, similarity in responses to the survey and how these changed from one survey to the next were recorded.

The mentioned secondary data was also analysed by way of content analysis. From a qualitative analysis perspective, the free-text survey responses were examined for evidence of the themes developed in the primary data analysis. Counting the responses that were relevant to this research provided some quantitative element to the study. Overall, adding this element of secondary data analysis provided some level of triangulation that helped validate the data (Clark *et al.*, 2021). The shortest free-text survey response consisted of four words, the longest of one hundred nineteen words, and on average the responses consisted of twenty-eight words.

3.2.4. Research methods – advantages and limitations

Semi-structured interviews were chosen as primary data collection instrument for this research project. Company X with its small number of staff was ideal for this method. A large percentage of the population of the company could be included in the project and copious amounts of data could be collected (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2016). Other qualitative research instruments, such as focus groups, were considered. However, it was established that such focus groups would not have provided any additional data for this specific project. Interviewing team leaders and team members individually and enquiring about how they specifically perceive leadership in their daily lives would be the best way of gathering relevant data (Ghauri, Gronhaug and Strange, 2020).

A quantitative approach to primary data collection was considered and quickly discarded. The aim of the project was to provide specific findings with relation to team leadership in a case study organisation with a small number of people. A survey would not have provided as rich data as the semi-structured interviews. Findings were not intended to be representative of the wider

population of leaders and members of virtual or hybrid teams beyond Company X (Clark *et al.*, 2021).

Whilst the interviews did not allow for collection of anonymous data from the researcher's perspective, the secondary data collected from the survey did provide totally anonymous quantitative and qualitative data. For anyone reading the report, however, all data has been presented in an anonymised way.

3.2.5. Quality of the chosen research strategy

Semi-structured interviews are innately not standardised; it is therefore difficult to assess whether an alternative researcher would have developed comparable data (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2016).

In addition, specific limitations and biases to this research were identified at the start of the project. The researcher applied mitigating actions to counteract said limitations throughout the research. The following table lists these limitations and mitigations.

Table 3.5, Research strategy limitations and applied mitigating actions

Identified limitation	Applied mitigation
The sample was limited in numbers (ten participants) in one organisation, all based in one geography (United Kingdom).	This research was not intended to represent the wider population but explored a specific situation and is portrayed accordingly.
“Interviewee or response bias” (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2016)	During the interviews the researcher pointed out to participants that they were asking the questions as a researcher and not as one the team leaders within Company X.
Snapshot nature of the research (cross-functional). Ideally more than one round of interviews would have been carried out. Time did not permit this.	The researcher needed to make sure there was sufficient time in the interviews to address the various work modes to help with gathering sufficient data for the research. The secondary data collection by way of analysing the two HR questionnaires that ran at a 2-month interval provided a limited longitudinal effect.
The researcher had to be careful not to choose participants they had a close relationship with for this research.	The chosen participants represented, in as equal proportion as possible, all departments of Company X.
The participants’ memories effected how rich or limited the gathered data was (Robson and McCartan, 2016).	The invitation to the interviews included details on behavioural interviewing being part of the process and each introduction to the interview also reminded the participants of it. Follow-up questions were used to help the participant explore memories in more detail.
The responses of staff working directly for the researcher could have been affected by the researcher being their supervisor.	The researcher stressed the anonymity of the research and its purpose clearly during the introduction.
Amount of data that could be analysed in the given time was limited.	The researcher relied on software to help with the data analysis and focused on the research question and objectives (Easterby-Smith <i>et al.</i> , 2018).
Researcher had limited experience in conducting research interviews.	A pilot interview was scheduled with sufficient time to make any changes before all other interviews were conducted.

3.2.6. Project approval and research ethics

Following the choice of Company X as a case study organisation, formal research approval from the Managing Director was requested. They agreed without hesitation.

Ethical considerations relating to this research were analysed and formulated at the outset of the project. The university's application form for ethical approval was submitted within the first three weeks of the project and ethical approval was received on 9 July 2021 (see Appendix 3).

4. Presentation of findings

This chapter presents the findings from the field research undertaken at Company X. The main objectives of the field work were to collect information on how teams are led at Company X and if there are differences between team leadership in the various work modes as perceived by leaders and followers. The first and main part of the chapter deals with the collected primary data. The secondary data is presented and discussed in the second part.

4.1 Findings from the primary data collection

4.1.1 Level 1 coding

The initial coding exercise included reading the transcripts and listening to the audio recordings multiple times (Braun and Clarke, 2013). This process generated 335 codes from the interviews (see Appendix 4 for the full list).

The researcher used GT. / HT. / VT. / X. prefixes of code names depending on how they related to the research question and objectives. These prefixes are GT. = general team leadership for codes that apply across all work modes at Company X during the pandemic; HT. = hybrid team leadership for codes that apply to the hybrid scenario; VT. = virtual team leadership for codes that apply to the virtual scenario; and X. for codes that provide some longitudinal aspect (see Table 4.1 for examples of this).

Table 4.1, Examples of initial codes (full schedule in Appendix 4)

Initial code	Found in this many interviews
GT. allocate tasks to people with the right skillset	3
GT. allow for flexibility in work hours in the day	2
GT. being approachable	2
GT. collaborate with the team	3
GT. communicate regularly to align tasks within team	2
GT. create opportunity for training	3
GT. delegate tasks to people with right skillset	2
GT. delegate tasks to people with right skillset and role	2
GT. keep team's skillset current to match tasks, add expertise when needed	2
HT. allow for flexibility in work patterns	1
HT. allow for personal interaction, chat in addition to exchange on tasks	2
HT. allows team member to flex work hours and days	2
HT. build up topics to discuss face to face when in office instead of virtually	1
HT. coordinate for collaboration face to face in office	2
HT. flexibility in start and finish time allows for better work life balance	2
HT. informal knowledge sharing easier	2
HT. plan office days for collaborative tasks	2
HT. social interaction in office really appreciated	2
VT. asynchronous communication	5
VT. blurred line between work and personal life	1
VT. communicate regularly with team members	4
VT. encourage social interactions virtually	2
VT. group topics before interacting	1
VT. hiring staff in virtual mode and fully integrate them is difficult	1
VT. make sure communication is structured	2
VT. regular contact to check in on how team members are doing	2
VT. synchronous communication	8
X. measuring success has changed	1
X. no change in how individual goals are measured	7
X. no change in leadership style during pandemic	2
X. team leader's priorities have not changed during pandemic	5

The table on the next page contains examples of quotes relating to four of the initial codes.

Table 4.2, Quotes coded to four initial codes

Initial code	Quotes
	I.6: “Specifically involving me in things that probably are outside of my role... broadening my knowledge of the company or being involved with them...”
GT. create opportunity for training	I.5: “Instead of me kind of critiquing it after they had done it and kind of making them feel as if what they were doing was always wrong, I thought what we would do is we would just get together on a call like this, open up the screen between us and begin to work through...”
HT. allow for flexibility in work patterns	I.2: “If there’s a member of the team that, you know, needs to work from home for a day because they’ve got contractors coming in because they’ve just moved flat.”
	I.2: “My team leader kept in contact with me to make sure I didn’t sort just drift away in what was a really uncertain, difficult time for me...”
VT. regular contact to check in on how team members are doing	I.8: “Just kept in touch, you know, initially three or four times a day...”
	I.8: “They contacted me, so there was always a link, a communication of some description... and that really helped...”
	I.7: “I can’t think of a difference in how we do it.”
X. no change in how individual goals are measured	I.8: “In terms of success measurement: No.”
	I.10: “No, I don’t think so.”

The 335 codes also included 64 codes, found 71 times, that described situations where interviewees mentioned the lack of something or a negative aspect of team leadership. For almost all positive examples given by the interviewees, others gave negative responses to the same question suggesting some inconsistency in how the various team leaders deal with situations (see Table 4.3 for examples).

Table 4.3, Positive vs. negative codes

Positive code and quote:	Negative code and quote:
HT. plan week with collaboration in office, solitary tasks at home	HT. lack of coordination of office days
I.2: “We tend to structure the week so that most of the meetings are on two or three days... load the two days with meetings and come in for two days... work on other tasks when I’m at home.”	I.4: “And although I have said to the team leader, we should really try and coordinate the fact that we’re both in on the same day. But that hasn’t yet occurred.”
VT. regular contact to check in on team members	VT. very little communication
I.8: “Just kept in touch, you know, initially three or four times a day.”	I.4: “I think I spoke to them once last week.”
VT. encourage social interactions virtually	GT. not encouraging social interaction of whole team
I.7: “And team socials during the pandemic, I really enjoyed them.”	I.3: “Generally no, we don’t socialise as such.”

4.1.2 Developing level 2 themes

Continuous review of the initial codes and transcripts led to the emergence of themes that were pertinent to this research project. These level 2 themes were arranged according to their relevance to the research question and objectives, as well as to their relevance to the published literature that was reviewed for this project (Braun and Clarke, 2013).

Twenty-three level 2 themes, some further broken down into sub-themes, emerged (see Table 4.4 for an extract from the level 2 themes schedule). Additionally, the previously mentioned codes providing some longitudinal aspects were also grouped separately. Table 4.6 later in the chapter provides more narrative and examples of these.

Table 4.4, Extract of level 2 themes and sub-themes (full schedule in Appendix 5)

Level 2 theme	Level 2 sub-theme (if applicable)	Found in this many interviews	Number of mentions
Advocating flexibility of work patterns (HT)	Flexibility in start and finish time allows for better work-life balance Flexible working hours Include staff input into hybrid mode structure In-office days for social interaction Optimise work for collaboration in office, solitary work elsewhere	9	36
Aligning team's work with wider organisational context		6	8
Being a role model		4	5
Being approachable		7	18
Being concerned with well-being of staff		8	24
Being protective of team to outside world		2	4
Celebrating success		7	8
Collaborating with team members		7	10
Communication, key to success	Communication in office less structured (HT) Communicate clearly on tasks, processes Communicate with team members regularly to make sure team aligned (VT) Communication is structured, planned (VT) Encourage active participation of team members in calls Encourage communication amongst the team members Establish frequency of communication Meeting etiquette (VT mainly) Social interaction through team calls (VT) Synchronous and asynchronous communication channels (VT) Use of communication channels to check on staff's well-being	10	96

The table on the following page contains examples of quotes relating to four of the level 2 themes.

Table 4.5, Quotes coded to four level 2 themes:

Level 2 theme	Quotes
Advocating flexibility of work patterns (HT)	I.1: "The flexible hours have been really good in terms of allowing us to travel at a time we feel more or less comfortable."
	I.4: "They are very flexible in that way... they don't expect me to be sat here all day long."
	I.10: "As long as I am available across the week for the number of hours that I'm supposed to work, it doesn't matter too much when I actually do it, as long as the work gets done."
Aligning team's work with wider organisational context	I.2: "The other teams do really just sort of have to follow, you know, the direction we're going, so I feel like no team could be more aligned than ours."
	I.4: "Whatever the goals Company X has, that's the purpose... we all need to aim towards the goals of the company."
	I.8: "I've consulted with different areas as well, just to make sure that what I'm writing reflects reality ... So, yes, I think we are aligned with the other areas of the company."
Being approachable	I.1: "From my perspective, I find them very easy to approach, very easy to raise any issues with them."
	I.5: "Don't worry about interrupting me or don't worry about anything like that. Just call me and let me know."
	I.7: "They are very, very accessible. So, I would feel able to talk to them about things."
	I.9: "And that's important that I make them feel that they can communicate with me and be honest with me and say if they think that something's wrong. So, you know, that sort of idea of an open door."
Being concerned with well-being of staff	I.1: "I don't think there was any expectation for it to become like that from my team leader ... I don't think they expected me to work from eight to six every day."
	I.2: "So it's important for me to have that time just to talk about how things are going."
	I.4: "Yeah, I mean, so that's, you know, making sure that I'm not getting too stressed over it all. Yeah, so they are good at that."
	I.7: "And they have got quite a paternalistic style. You know, our well-being is important."

Interestingly, most interviewees, when asked about the priorities of a team leader's role, described the leader to be concerned with their team's well-being, to be approachable, and to collaborate with their staff (52 occasions; see Table 4.4 above for some quotes). All these themes relate to having good relationships and generally to the social aspect of the role.

Intriguingly, dealing with conflict as a subject only came up in two interviews (I.3, I.5), whereas the topic is dealt with in the published literature quite prominently (Buchanan and Huczynski, 2019; Gilson *et al.*, 2021). The qualitative data gathered in the interviews suggests that team leadership at Company X was more concerned with letting people get on with their work and the previously mentioned focus on good relationships.

Also worthy of note is the fact that a lack of structured senior leadership team processes were mentioned by three interviewees: “the EXCO team, whilst it's there in name it doesn't really exist”, “I report into the MD, but I don't believe there is a leadership team as such”, “I think that the leadership team changes according to what's going on at the time”, “there isn't really an opportunity for the senior people in the firm to sit around as a unit and think...”.

Other themes that emerged from the interviews related to the structuring of the team and general support of team processes. For example, structuring and monitoring team and processes, ensuring the right skillset is available, providing clarity of roles.

The researcher also looked at whether the collected data suggested any changes in how team leadership was exhibited in the various work modes. Remarkably, no change between the various work modes during the pandemic were described for most team leadership tasks grouped in the Level 2 themes of ‘Setting direction, ensuring team delivers, and keeping external stakeholders happy’ and ‘Measuring success’: priorities of team leaders did not change, how success is measured did not change, leadership style did not change (see Table 4.6). The lack of evidence of changes between the virtual to the hybrid mode could be affected by the timing of the interviews. Company X had only switched to the hybrid mode in July 2021 and the interviews took place in September 2021.

Table 4.6, Examples of how no changes between the office, virtual and hybrid scenario were observed:

	Quotes
Have priorities changed? Has style changed?	I.3: “I don’t think so, no. I mean, from a point of workload, work procedures, and policies that more or less stayed the same.” I.4: “No, it’s the way the team leader works. So it hasn’t changed.”
Level 2 theme: Setting direction, ensuring team delivers, and keeping external stakeholders happy’	I.6: “They haven’t really changed.” I.7: “So I think their priorities, they’ve not really changed.” I.10: “Has the lockdown changed the priorities? I don’t think it has.”
Has the way goals are measured changed?	I.1: “Not really.” I.3: “No, not really.”
Level 2 theme: Measuring success	I.6: “Mid-year reviews, year-end reviews, goals have all continued, as they would have done.” I.7: “No, I can’t think of a difference in how we do it.”

There was evidence for changes between scenarios in the following areas: the appreciation of flexibility provided by the hybrid system came through strongly (as evidenced in Table 4.4 above). The social and informal interaction opportunities provided by being back in the office were also highly appreciated, whilst differences in how people communicated in the virtual and hybrid mode were also reported (see Table 4.7).

Table 4.7, Quotes showing hybrid specific benefits and differences in VT and HT

Level 2 theme	Quotes
Communication in office less structured (HT) vs VT communication being structured, planned (Level 2 sub-theme comparison)	I.1: “The difference with being in the office where you can just call on someone who is at the other end of the office or beside you in the office.”
	I.5: “I find that on Zoom and MS Teams calls, people tend not to talk over one another actually quite as frequently as they might do if they were in a room together.”
	I.8: “In the virtual mode, that has meant that I’ve had to book time with them so that we can discuss those things.”
	I.9: “It [communication] has probably become a little bit more structured working from home.”
	I.6: “If there’s something that’s a bit on the periphery that it might not be mentioned in a virtual call, whereas actually, if you’re in the same room, people will kind of go...”
Informal and social interaction in office environment (HT)	I.6: “People speaking more openly and, you know, giving more information because we’re in the office.”
	I.4: “I did feel very isolated... When it was announced that we were going to go back to the office two days a week, I was actually over the moon.”
	I.6: “You realize how much easier it is to have someone sat next to you as sounding board, or have someone to, you know, your manager sitting next to you to run through things.”
	I.6: “From a meeting point of view, collaboration is different in face-to-face because I think you actually have more time to kind of get to know each other as people.”
	I.8: “It’s just a bit more social when we’re in the office together.”
	I.9: “I’ve really enjoyed going back... You’re picking up body language.”

Communication as an overarching theme came through at level 2 and will be discussed in more detail in the next section.

4.1.3 Level 3 themes and model

Further review of the collected data and the level 2 themes resulted in additional grouping opportunities emerging that led the researcher to developing level 3 themes, as presented in Table 4.8 (Braun and Clarke, 2006).

Table 4.8, Level 3 themes (in alphabetical order)

Level 3 theme	Level 2 theme
Caring for people	Being concerned with well-being of staff
Collaborating with the team	Being approachable
	Collaborating with team members
Communication, key to success	Communication, key to success
Developing team members	Developing team members
Encouraging social interactions	Informal and social interaction in office environment (HT)
	Social interaction through team calls (VT)
Flexibility of hybrid working	Advocating flexibility of work patterns (HT)
Keeping team focused on goals and success	Being a role model
	Celebrating success
	Measuring success
	Setting direction, ensuring team delivers, and keeping external stakeholders happy
Providing structure	Ensuring the right skillset is available
	Providing clarity of roles
	Structuring and monitoring team and processes
	Mechanism in place to deal with conflict when it arises
Support team to be as effective as possible	Supporting team members so they can work effectively
	Trusting people to get on with their work
	Supporting innovative ways of working
	Supporting diverse ideas and viewpoints
Team alignment with outside world	Being protective of team to outside world
	Aligning team's work with wider organisational context
	Encouraging collaboration with other teams

Quotes relating to the Level 3 themes can be found in these tables:

Table 4.2: Developing team members; Flexibility of hybrid working; Communication, key to success.

Table 4.5: Flexibility of hybrid working; Team aligned with outside world; Collaborating with the team; Caring for people.

Table 4.7: Communication, key to success; Encouraging social interaction.

Table 4.9: Communication, key to success; Keeping team focused on goals and success; Providing structure; Support team to be as effective as possible.

Since these level 3 themes were developed from the initial level 1 codes through to the level 2 themes, they include a mixture of generally applicable codes, virtual team leadership codes, and hybrid team leadership codes. The only level 3 theme that is purely related to the hybrid scenario is “Flexibility of hybrid working”.

The following paragraphs provide some insight into how these level 3 themes provide new aspects to the research.

Unsurprisingly, communication as a theme came up in all ten interviews. Both team leaders and team members described various ways of how they communicated with each other when working remotely, how they established regular intervals to discuss tasks as well personal topics. The lack of communication was also brought up by a few interviewees (see previously mentioned quotes in Table 4.3).

The focus on developing staff was another area that appeared important to the team leaders and team members at Company X. Leaders at Company X found ways of creating opportunities for training and engaged in some coaching and mentoring activities. The activities reached across all work mode scenarios and various teams (see Appendix 6 for some examples in addition to previously evidenced quotes in Table 4.3).

Another new theme emerged that described how team leaders kept their teams focused on their goals. Team leaders at Company X were described as setting direction, leading by example, and acting as role models. They measured their team’s success mainly by measuring individual goals, an activity that did not change throughout the various work modes during the pandemic, and by looking at team-wide goal measures. They also celebrated success, often by saying “thank you” and making a point of mentioning achievements of individuals in company-wide meetings (see Appendix 6 for examples).

A further theme developed that was concerned with a team leader supporting their team and enabling them to perform at their best. Team leaders were described as trusting their teams to “get on with their work” and as being ready to support the team when needed. These quite diverse activities fitted together under the general support idea.

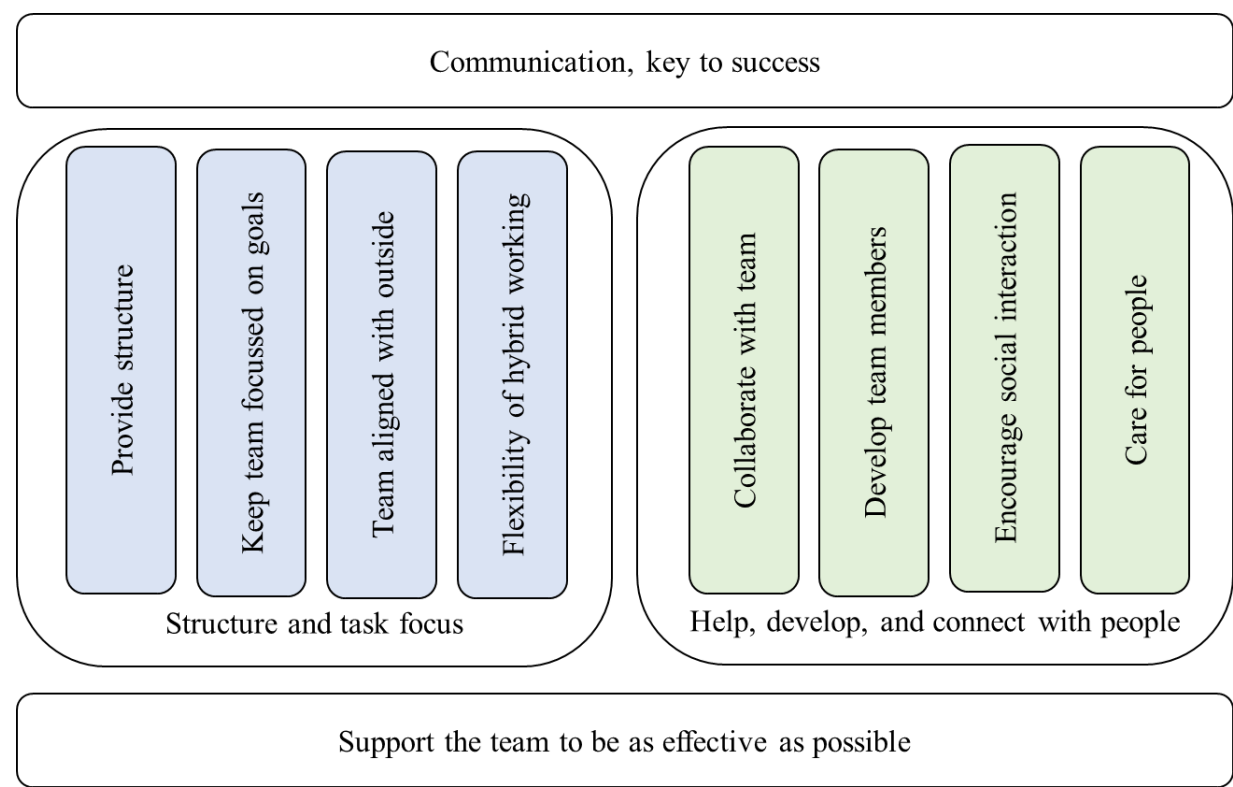
The table on the next page contains examples of quotes relating to four of these level 3 themes. See Appendix 6 for quotes relating to all ten themes.

Table 4.9, Example quotes relating to four level 3 themes:

Level 3 theme	Quotes
Communication, key to success	I.2: "Regular communication and keeping us informed in team meetings about the progress of the project." I.5: "I make sure that I'm catching up with both of them a couple of times a week." I.6: "People speaking more openly and, you know, giving more information because we're in the office." I.8: "Just kept in touch, you know, initially three or four times a day..."
Keeping team focused on goals and success	I.1: "They sent me a really nice message saying thank you very much and well done." I.2: "The team leader congratulated me on passing my exam." I.2: "They're a role model for how everyone in the company should conduct themselves in terms of their enthusiasm and the effort they apply to their role." I.2: "Things like making sure we hit our targets, meet our deadlines, that hasn't changed." I.10: "It goes back to the plan. Have we done the tasks in the plan that we were expecting to do?"
Providing structure	I.1: "Everybody has a clear place within their team." I.2: "Organising the team." I.3: "Be open and upfront and have these meetings where we can discuss whatever the issue is." I.6: "Making sure things like team meetings happen." I.6: "Everyone has kind of quite defined roles."
Support team to be as effective as possible	I.1: "They let me get on with my work." I.1: "They tend to give me guidance if I need it." I.2: "They took the opportunity to hire someone with different expertise, a different background, and a slightly different role to support us with our tasks." I.2: "When we have a new initiative or a new innovation that we're trying to carry out, I think everyone tends to know what we are looking to get out of it. And that comes from my team leader's guidance." I.8: "They've been really useful in kind of pointing me in the right direction when I've needed help and guidance." I.9: "Because of the fact they couldn't travel and do their jobs in the way that they'd done before, we were able to get them sort of repurposed to an extent." I.9: "We get lots of evidence of that through the fact that we do new things."

The researcher saw the opportunity to further analyse the ten level 3 themes developed from the research at Company X and has regrouped them into a model (see figures 4.1).

Figure 4.1, Hybrid team leadership model, based on research at Company X, C. Mares



As previously discussed, communication came up in all interviews, across various topics, and as key to effective team leadership. The themes displayed in blue are concerned with structure and task focus. The themes shown in green relate to helping, developing, and connecting with people. Like communication, “supporting the team to be as effective as possible” is also an overarching element of effective team leadership indicating that a team leader enables and supports their staff with everything they do.

Whilst the model has been developed with Company X’s hybrid scenario in mind, only one of the themes relates exclusively to hybrid working (flexibility of hybrid working). As discussed, the collected data suggests that most topics and themes at Company X are just as relevant for office, virtual, and hybrid work modes. Even when Company X is in hybrid mode, there is a percentage of staff who work in virtual mode because they are working from home and engaging with other colleagues virtually.

4.2 Secondary data, relevant to the research

Introductory note: the first HR survey on hybrid working at Company X was distributed to all employees and long-term contractors of Company X (15 people, 15 responses, August 2021), whereas the second survey was only sent to the employees of Company X (10 people, 10 responses, October 2021). A direct comparison of responses is therefore difficult, but some longitudinal effect can still be achieved.

4.2.1 Analysis of quantifiable responses from both surveys

Table 4.10, Company X's HR-survey results – longitudinal effect

Question	Survey 1, August 2021 Responses			Survey 2, October 2021 Responses			Change Responses		
	Positive	Neutral / to some extent	Negative	Positive	Neutral / to some extent	Negative	Positive	Neutral / to some extent	Negative
Are you able to schedule your working week with office days focused on collaboration, and WFH days focused on routine tasks and solitary work?	33%	67%	0%	80%	20%	0%	47%	-47%	
How are you enjoying your new working pattern?	87%	13%	0%	80%	20%	0%	-7%	7%	
Do you feel that Company X's use of technology supports your productivity?	87%	13%	0%	80%	20%	0%	-7%	7%	
Is your manager actively supporting you and promoting this new way of working?	87%	13%	0%	80%	20%	0%	-7%	7%	
Do you feel safe, in relation to Covid?	60%	13%	27%	40%	10%	50%	-20%	-3%	23%
Does your new working pattern help productivity?	80%	7%	13%	40%	30%	30%	-40%	23%	17%
What can we do to make you feel more safe?	free text only / N/A								
If you have encountered any difficulties while getting used to this new way of working, please state what they are.	free text only / N/A								
Are there any changes that you would like us to make?	free text only / N/A								

The data suggests a considerable improvement to how staff at Company X were able to structure their work week around collaborative days in the office and solitary work at home. Given the two-month interval between the surveys this would suggest a general positive trend in this respect.

There was relatively little change in how people were enjoying the work pattern, how IT was helping them with productivity, and how the managers supported them. The responses were mostly positive in both surveys.

Staff felt less safe in relation to Covid-19 in October 2021. This was a time of general increase in Covid-19 cases in the UK therefore not surprising.

Staff's perception of their overall productivity dropped considerably between surveys.

4.2.2 Qualitative analysis of responses linked to the research project

Table 4.11, Responses to research related team leadership aspects

Survey question	Free-text responses (Level 3 theme)
Is your manager actively supporting you and promoting this new way of working?	Survey 1:
	“Mondays and Fridays are not filled with meetings. Time for relatively spontaneous face-to-face meetings has been made during office days.” (Flexibility of hybrid working)
	“My manager is setting a good example to the rest of the team.” (Keeping team focused on goals and success)
	Survey 2:
Are you able to schedule your working week with office days focused on collaboration, and WFH days focused on routine tasks and solitary work?	“Encouraging collaboration when in office.” (Collaborating with the team)
	“My manager plans the week in accordance with office / WFH days.” (Flexibility of hybrid working).
	“Yes, we are trying to collaborate on the days we are both in the office.” (Collaborating with the team)
	Survey 1:
	“It would be good to focus more on inter-departmental collaboration after the holidays.” (Team alignment with outside world)
	“I try to be in the office when most people are there so that allows me to collaborate with colleagues if needs be.” (Collaborating with the team)
	“Even when WFH there is a need to collaborate, you can't just do that on a single day. Collaboration via calls is fine but you get more creativity from personal interaction.” (Encouraging social interactions)
	Survey 2:
	“It's becoming a routine for me and my colleagues. I have noticed fewer requests for collaborative work on the WFH days, other than for urgent / ad-hoc situations.” (Flexibility of hybrid working)
	“It's not always easy to have the people you want to collaborate with in on the same days as you.” (Flexibility of hybrid working)

	“I am able to arrange my working week so that on days where I require collaboration I can meet up with colleagues.” (Flexibility of hybrid working)
Does your new working pattern help productivity?	Survey 1: “I am generally more productive in the office.” “I get more work done at home.” “I definitely get more work done working from home. In the office there are more distractions and calls on my time.” “Easier in the office to catch up with others and share priorities/work levels.”
(Flexibility of hybrid working)	Survey 2: “Being selfish I am more efficient at home.” “Some tasks are easier to tackle when at home and others are easier in the office.” “My overall productivity is improving. More complex issues discussed face to face seem to get sorted much more effectively. I feel more motivated in the office and feel more part of the wider team.” “More inclined to work less hours as commuting and there are more distractions in the office.”
Responses from various other questions	“Be sensible and perhaps more flexible on dictating the number of days people should be in the office. Don't have people in there just for the sake of it.” (Keeping team focused on goals and success) “I enjoy the new flexible working pattern. It contributes to a better work/life balance.” (Flexibility of hybrid working) “It demonstrates trust in employees to take responsibility for the work that they need to complete. We are not required to be in the office just for the sake of being there.” (Support team to be as effective as possible) “The more flexible office hours help with the commute. From a social interaction point of view being in the office with colleagues helps.” (Flexibility of hybrid working) “Very good to be with colleagues again.” (Encouraging social interactions) “I think we should look critically at blended meetings and how we can make them more inclusive of the people who are not physically in the room.” (Support team to be as effective as possible)

The responses suggest that Company X’s team leaders actively supported their team members in getting used to the new hybrid working mode by leading by example and by structuring their team’s work week according to the new home/office day schedule.

Looking at the more general question on scheduling of the week, the responses suggest mixed views. During the first survey, staff seemed to be getting used to the working pattern, whereas during the second survey the responses could be interpreted as people were already used to the

new mode. In both surveys, some critical views were expressed about it not being possible to exclusively collaborate when in the office and totally focus on solitary work when working from home.

Respondents had opposite views on whether they were more productive at home or in the office. Commuting time was also given as a reason to work fewer hours when in the office. Blended meetings and related challenges with inclusivity were raised.

The opportunity for social interaction in the office was seen as a positive, as was the work/life balance offered by the hybrid mode.

4.3 Summary

The collected data suggests that team leaders at Company X were concerned with supporting and developing their staff in many aspects of their roles. Team leaders were offering guidance, providing structure, and caring for their staff. They communicated with each other using various technologies and advocating social interactions when working remotely. The anonymous HR surveys also generally showed that team members appreciated how their leaders supported them in the new hybrid mode.

However, the data also suggests some inconsistency in how team leaders interacted with their teams. Even though most interviewees expressed how they experienced team leadership in a positive way, several also described situations that led the researcher to generate negative codes or codes describing the lack of an activity that their staff would have expected.

How much staff at Company X appreciated the flexibility that hybrid working offers emerged clearly from the interviews; this was also confirmed in the analysis of the secondary data. The secondary data also showed a vast improvement in the home/office work scheduling at Company X in October 2021 compared to August 2021.

Finally, researching team leadership at Company X led to the development of a model consisting of four categories: communication; structure and task; helping, developing, and connecting with people; support the team to be as effective as possible.

5. Analysis of findings in relation to published ideas

This chapter analyses the key findings from the previous chapter in more detail and establishes links to published literature.

The research established ten Level 3 themes that describe effective team leadership at Company X as the organisation transitioned to a hybrid way of working. These ten themes were further grouped into four categories and formed part of a hybrid team leadership model (see figure 4.1 in the previous chapter for the model). The following paragraphs discuss those categories.

5.1 Communication, key to success

Communication, as a crucial component of effective team leadership at Company X, came through in the collected data which parallels views of Wheelan (2016), who also regards it as important enabler of effective team leadership. All themes that emerged in the research were influenced by how good team leaders' communication skills were.

This research found that when Company X transitioned to virtual working, team leaders showed adaptability and quickly established new technology-based communication norms to keep in regular contact with their staff which is similar to the theory by Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato (2021) and Chamakiotis, Panteli and Davison (2021). Additionally, the use of communication technology provides a link between a team's work and the wider organisation, can help with providing structure, and keeps teams focused on their goals (Reyes, Luna and Salas, 2021) which are practices that were also observed at Company X.

The research revealed that team leaders also used communication channels to encourage social interactions amongst team members which is aligned with the views of a number of scholars (Dinh *et al.*, 2021; Gilson *et al.*, 2021; Kirkman and Stoverink, 2021). However, the collected data also suggests inconsistent communication norms between teams. During the initial phases of the pandemic and lockdowns, some team leaders did not speak to their staff or contact them asynchronously for days which does not correspond to best practices suggested by Malhotra, Majchrzak and Rosen norms (2007). The leaders may have been operating in crisis mode at the time thus neglecting regular team leadership norms as Caringal-Go *et al.* found in their research (2021).

The research showed that Company X's teams started using messaging services to connect more informally when the organisation went into virtual mode. Unsurprisingly, this way of communicating is aligned with recent theories (Chamakiotis, Panteli and Davison, 2021). Interestingly, better meeting etiquette at Company X was reported in video calls compared to in-person meetings whereas Wotapka (2021) describes virtual calls to be more prone to becoming uncontrollable. This could be an indication of team leaders becoming more aware of speaking over each other during virtual calls.

5.2 Structure and task focus

The research established that team leaders at Company X were providing structure to their teams, making sure the right skillset was available, and people knew what everyone was supposed to deliver. These findings reflect the view of Kayworth and Leidner (2002) and Newman, Ford and Marshall (2020) on clarity of roles and structure supporting team effectiveness. Company X has been structured with its current teams for quite some time and this could be a reason why there was not much of an issue with clarity on structure and roles.

Ways of dealing with conflict seemed to be in place at Company X, albeit conflict management was only mentioned marginally in the interviews. However, scholars describe it as an important role of a team leader that also supports effective team working (Morgan, Paucar-Caceres and Wright, 2014; Buchanan and Huczynski, 2019). Company X's staff seemed more concerned with getting on with their work and their colleagues than looking to engage in conflict. A harmonious way of working seemed to be in place in most teams, which reflects the views of Kline (2011).

Literature on virtual and hybrid teams suggest measuring goals by looking at output (Carroll and Conboy, 2020) and the study found that individual goals at Company X were measured via formal mid-year and year-end assessments that indeed looked at output measures. The company had adopted this formal process before the pandemic started therefore no change was required, nor reported by any interviewees. Interestingly, whilst the research showed that their team's goals were clear to everyone, how they were measured hardly came up in the interviews when the researcher inquired about how team goals were assessed. Yet, researchers would regard the measurement of team goals as critical to team success (Wheelan, 2016; Kogler Hill, 2019).

Remarkably, whilst some teams within Company X were described as perfectly aligned within the organisation and its other teams, some described their team as the opposite. Good alignment

with other teams and the wider organisation is widely regarded as contributing to a team's success (West, 2012; Katzenbach and Smith, 2015; Wheelan, 2016). Company X's teams that did not rely on other teams to complete their tasks were the ones reporting misalignment with the rest of the organisation.

Crucially and as already mentioned, the flexibility that hybrid working offers was very popular with all interviewees. None of the interviewees considered going back to the office five days a week in the near future as De Smet *et al.* (2021) also found in their survey. Theories on hybrid working also suggest structuring home/office schedules according to the need for in-person communication (Gratton, 2021; Hooijberg and Watkins, 2021; Whillans, Perlow and Turek, 2021) and the research found that Company X's leaders initially struggled with this new concept but most improved over time. Nevertheless, some did not make progress which points towards Company X maybe requiring to plan hybrid working more consistently for it to be successful longer-term as Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato (2021) found in their research.

5.3 Helping, developing, and connecting with people

The research showed that it was important for team leaders to collaborate well with their teams and to create an environment that encouraged their team members to approach them for help, which is similar to how Keyworth and Leidner (2002) and Kogler Hill (2019) describe effective team leaders. Furthermore, the way Katzenbach and Smith (2015) in their theory advocate for team leaders to be fully integrated with the team was also observed to some extent within Company X. A sense of camaraderie came across based on trusting relationships.

Team leaders at Company X often created learning opportunities for their staff. They acted as mentors and coaches throughout the pandemic even though doing so in the virtual environment was particularly difficult, which has similarly been established by Kirkman and Stoverink (2021) in their study.

Surprisingly, the need for training in communication technology did not feature significantly in interviewees' responses. Yet, the literature regards training in this area as vital for effective virtual and hybrid team work (Settle-Murphy, 2012; Liao, 2017). The fact that only Zoom and MS Teams platforms were used for virtual communication at Company X could have helped with staff not facing issues with the grasp of technology.

Interestingly, whilst developing others was on team leaders' minds, their own development did not come up in the interviews. According to various scholars however, leaders of virtual and hybrid teams need to continuously adapt and develop their skills to be able to cope with everchanging requirements presented by the new work models (Ford, Piccolo and Ford, 2017; Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato, 2021). As previously stated, Company X may have been working in crisis mode and consequently team leaders' own development did not feature high on their agenda (Caringal-Go *et al.*, 2021).

Connecting with their staff remained an important aspect of Company X's team leaders' roles throughout the pandemic. During the pure virtual working phase only quite structured and planned interactions took place that made it difficult for people to connect socially as Whillans, Perlow and Turek (2021) likewise established in their research.

A real effort was also made by many team leaders even in that phase to encourage social and fun interactions via communication technology. It seems that in line with the research findings of Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato (2021), once the company transitioned to hybrid working, the impromptu connections suddenly started happening as Company X's staff spent time together in the office again.

A genuine care for people became apparent as a key quality of team leaders at Company X which also parallels the views of Chamakiotis, Panteli and Davison (2021) that leaders of hybrid teams are particularly concerned with their staff's well-being and how the new scenario affects them.

5.4 Supporting the team to be as effective as possible

Literature on general team leadership describes how team leaders ensure their teams can operate smoothly and how they must establish trust to do so (Lencioni, 2011; Buchanan and Huczynski, 2019) and the research similarly showed that Company X's leaders made sure their staff could work independently knowing support was available when needed. No micromanaging was reported even when the organisation switched from co-located working to virtual working, which suggests a trusting relationship between team leaders and their team members was in place.

The research also established that Company X's team leaders contributed to their teams' effective operation by supporting diverse opinions and ideas by way of promoting discussions that led to collaboration, which is similar to what Tannenbaum and Salas (2020) classify as some driving

forces behind team effectiveness. However, diversity only came up in the interviews in terms of different opinions and views; no other aspects of diversity were mentioned.

Whilst a team leader's role in innovation also appears extensively in the literature (Wheelan, 2016; Super, 2020), the topic only featured in a couple of the interviews in connection with new ways of working and processes. Company X's business is steady and highly regulated which could explain the lack of innovative actions reported by the research participants.

5.5 Of further interest

As previously mentioned, each category showed some inconsistency in how the various teams at Company X were led by members of the leadership team. At the same time, a lack of clarity in the organisation's leadership team composition, structure, and roles was reported, which goes against established theories on effective team leadership (West, 2012). It may be possible to identify a lack of a shared mental model from these findings. The leadership team's lack of regular and structured interaction could have contributed further to this.

The research established that Company X's team leaders did not change how individual goals were set when the organisation switched from office-based to virtual to hybrid working. However, published literature suggests that offering staff more inspiring goals, linked to the new freedom that hybrid working offers, could lead to increased productivity (Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato, 2021). It is possible that Company X's team leaders simply did not see the need to change the process because it had worked fine up to then.

The reported drop in productivity level that was perceived by Company X's staff, as reported in the secondary data analysis, contradicts the findings of a recent McKinsey survey (Alexander *et al.*, 2021). It may be possible that a less structured home/office routine coupled with less frequent communication between team leaders and staff gave rise to this result.

5.6 Summary

This chapter has discussed how virtual and hybrid team leadership is perceived at Company X and how the findings relate to published literature. The four categories of the hybrid team leadership model, based on research at Company X, incorporate elements from various theories on team working and team leadership.

Effective team leadership in these scenarios include the following key elements: communication norms that help teams navigate the transitions from office-based to virtual to hybrid working; providing continuity in structure, and keeping their teams focused on their goals; helping, developing, and connecting with their staff; caring for people; and supporting smooth teamwork.

Some inconsistencies between how leaders led their teams at Company X and how the leadership team interacted were uncovered in this research.

An important aspect of qualitative research is also establishing the validity of the research. The information from the interviews has been analysed thoroughly, and secondary data has been used to provide triangulation (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill, 2016). The researcher believes that the consistent and iterative approach to the analysis offers a level of trustworthiness to this research (Creswell and Creswell, 2018). It is acknowledged that some findings support arguments found in the literature, whereas some areas discussed widely in the published works did not feature in the research findings.

6. Conclusions and recommendations

This dissertation set out to research what constitutes effective team leadership at Company X, the case study organisation, as it transitioned from office-based to virtual to hybrid working during the global Covid-19 pandemic. It also looked at whether there were differences in how team leadership was perceived in the various scenarios.

This chapter reflects on the research findings and analysis with the aim of developing a small number of key suggestions on how team leadership at Company X can be improved when its staff work virtually and, more importantly, as the organisation establishes its longer-term hybrid work mode.

The research has established that effective team leadership at Company X, during the pandemic-driven evolution of work modes, included the following:

Communication, a vital component of effective team leadership

Team leaders quickly adapted to the new normal and established effective new technology-based communication norms (Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato, 2021). These norms included an encouragement for social interactions, achieved via asynchronous and synchronous communication means. All themes that were established in the research were influenced by how well team leaders communicated with others. However, some inconsistency of communication norms between teams was also recognised. This inconsistency is addressed as part of the recommendations.

Providing structure and keeping the team focused on its tasks

Team leaders gave their teams structure and made sure the skillset within the teams was right for the tasks they were tackling. The new hybrid working scenario required team leaders to help with creating a routine of effective home/office working. Everyone's role and contribution was transparent (Newman, Ford and Marshall, 2020). The fact that Company X's team structure had been in place for some time likely contributed to clarity in roles and how teams fitted together. The teams were supported in remaining focused on their goals through an output-focused performance review process that did not change during the pandemic (Carroll and Conboy, 2020). Yet, how team-wide goals were measured was not obvious to followers. Furthermore, team leaders kept focus on task delivery through leading their teams by example. Mechanisms of dealing with conflict were in place, albeit the topic only arose to some extent. And whilst most teams were

aligned with other parts of the organisation, some inconsistency was noted and will form part of a recommendation.

Helping, developing, and connecting with people

Effective team leadership was built on good collaboration between team leader and their team members. An open door policy that supported trust building was observed (Gilson *et al.*, 2015). Development of staff was also high on the agenda of team leaders. However, their own development may have been neglected during the crisis mode operating model that the organisation had to adapt (Caringal-Go *et al.*, 2021). It was important for leaders to connect with their team members during this time. Social interactions were difficult when the whole organisation operated virtually, but even then, some of the leaders ensured these happened. Hybrid working enabled staff to connect more informally when they were in the office (Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato, 2021). Staff really appreciated this. Furthermore, a general care for people became apparent as a key quality of team leaders at the organisation.

Providing support so the team can be as effective as possible

Team leaders provided support when needed but also trusted their staff to get on with their work. No micromanaging and a trusting environment that enables effective working was reported (Lencioni, 2011). Voicing diverse ideas was encouraged and formed part of collaborative discussions (Tannenbaum and Salas, 2020). The research also discovered team leadership support for innovative ways of working. However, this only came up marginally.

Hardly any difference was reported in terms of how team leadership was perceived in the various work modes as the organisation transitioned during the pandemic. However, the flexibility offered by hybrid working stood out as an important and attractive part of working at Company X. Team leadership support and championing of this aspect is therefore deemed crucial.

Having interviewed 66% of Company X's staff (ten people) gives the researcher confidence that this research has sufficiently evaluated and analysed the situation within the organisation. At the same time, it is acknowledged that the generated data is not sufficient to generalise the findings to other organisations.

The research has also highlighted some opportunities for team leadership at Company X to be further developed. The focus of these recommendations is on the organisation's hybrid mode that will form part of its longer term operating model.

Recommendation 1: Bring consistency into team leadership across the organisation

Inconsistencies in team leadership aspects were established in this research project. At the same time, excellent examples of hybrid team leadership were discovered. Since each team leader at Company X reports into the Managing Director of the organisation, sharing best practices to maximise the positive attributes of leadership across the organisation should be an achievable objective. Regular leadership meetings could be scheduled as a platform for sharing such best practices. Better team alignment and company-wide communication could result from this.

Recommendation 2: Maximise on the opportunities that hybrid working offers

The team leaders could maximise on the freedom that hybrid working offers by working with their teams on developing more inspiring, productivity-increasing individual goals and collectively develop team goals (Birkinshaw, Gudka and D'Amato, 2021). In this process, team leaders could also review the long-established goal setting system and adapt it if not fit for the new way of working.

Team leaders could also more actively help their staff structure their work week so that tasks that benefit from in-person communication can be performed in the office (Gratton, 2021; Hooijberg and Watkins, 2021).

Recommendation 3: Develop team leadership skills, needed for the new way of working

Now that the organisation is out of crisis mode and hybrid working is becoming established, team leaders should look at their current skillsets. During the pandemic they have mainly looked at developing their team members, but being able to perform at their best in the new hybrid mode may require personal development on their part as well (Hooijberg and Watkins, 2021).

It would be interesting to compare the four categories that this research established as characteristics of effective hybrid working at Company X with further emerging research into hybrid working to assess if they are more widely applicable.

7. Reflections on the dissertation process

Throughout this module, I have reflected on my learning using Gibbs' Reflective Cycle (Gibbs, 2013). The first few weeks of the dissertation module were dedicated to the development of a clear research question and research objectives and to putting together a clear proposal. My supervisor Dr Boak and I kickstarted our working relationship with a Zoom call on day two of the module; regular exchanges followed throughout the duration of this module. During this initial proposal development phase, I researched the topic of my dissertation quite intensely. The RKC lectures provided additional helpful information.

Following the submission of the research proposal, I scheduled the interviews with the participants at Company X and started developing the interview guide, a process recommended by Ghauri, Gronhaug and Strange (2020). At the same time, I started the outline of this dissertation paper, populated it with sections from the proposal, and continued my literature review.

The field research took place as planned in September 2021. The interviewees shared their views on team leadership at Company X openly with me which provided me with a plethora of data to analyse. I learned how to use NVivo for the transcription and analysis of the interviews. In all, the analysis took approximately two months.

I spent the remainder of the module writing up my findings, analysis, conclusions from the research, and my reflections.

Throughout the module, I have kept in contact with other students who were working on their dissertations via WhatsApp groups and one-to-one chats. I did not engage too much on the RKC online forum for the module.

I was quite nervous at the start of the dissertation module. This was my first independent academic research project. Team leadership in this new Covid-19 world is also a topic that I am passionate about, and I wanted to produce a good quality paper.

Looking back, I found the thematic analysis especially hard. My initial coding generated many codes, and I was worried I would not be able to find common themes amongst the data. It felt impossible to "see the wood for the trees" as Braun and Clarke (2013) put it nicely. I felt a sense of relief once themes slowly started to emerge.

I feel grateful to all my colleagues for their openness during the interviews. Coupled with this, I also feel proud of having managed to successfully lead the interviews and obtain rich data for my analysis.

At times, I have missed the amazing interaction with fellow students on the RKC online campus that I had experienced in the taught modules. Using WhatsApp as a means of communication has somewhat made up for that though.

I also feel a sense of pride for having produced this dissertation in English, having not done any academic writing in this language before.

I have also really enjoyed learning new skills in the process. It has been fun.

On the plus side, the primary data collection via the interviews went really well. Even though everyone was busy, all participants made sure they put aside sufficient time to go through all my questions. My interview guide helped me steer the conversations so that relevant data could be collected.

Moreover, the use of IT has also been very successful. The hardware has worked well throughout. The various software packages used for the transcription, analysis of data, writing of the dissertation, and storage on the cloud have worked impeccably.

Finally, the interaction with my supervisor has been excellent. Dr Boak's feedback has enabled me to critically review my draft chapters and look at them with a fresh mind.

On the negative side, my planned timing during the middle of the dissertation module slipped due to my underestimating of other work-related study commitments I had to fulfil at that time.

In addition, deliberating whether to learn how to use NVivo for my data analysis or whether to stick with software I already knew took longer than anticipated.

Lastly, only two HR surveys took place during this dissertation module which somewhat limited the amount of secondary data I could collect for my research.

On reflection, I believe the interviews generally went well because of my ability to connect with the interviewees. How I prepared for each interview played a big role in this. I made sure I had enough time to myself before each meeting to focus my mind and get ready to listen beautifully according to Kline (2011). Each interviewee deserved my full attention so they could in turn open their minds during the interviews.

In retrospect, having used computers all my working life has contributed to me being very aware of hardware and software reliability. I have also experienced loss of data in the past which then had to be reproduced. I therefore went into the dissertation module with a clear plan on how to deal with IT and as a result have not encountered any issues. Had I not thought about this thoroughly beforehand, I may have struggled.

I believe that my detailed preparation for each Zoom call with my supervisor has contributed to how well the working relationship has developed. I believe that keeping my supervisor informed of my progress also helped. I am grateful to have been assigned Dr Boak, an expert in this field, as my supervisor.

In hindsight, I could have worked on my time management better throughout the module. Even though I had a plan in place, it was at times too ambitious and did not sufficiently consider how my busy work schedule affected how much energy I had left to work on my dissertation. From previous MBA modules, I should have known that for me academic writing is a slow process. I should have planned for this better.

Looking back, I feel that my inexperience in qualitative data analysis and the related nervousness contributed to the slow decision making regarding what software to use. Even though I consulted with other students on this question, I was apprehensive about choosing the wrong approach which delayed the process.

On balance, the experience has been very positive. I believe that my choice of subject has played a role in this. I am just as interested in the topic today as I was at the outset of the project.

Additionally, positive feedback from the interviewees on how they felt the interviews went has also contributed to keeping my motivation high.

As a result of undertaking this dissertation module, I have started to develop research skills, such as thorough research of published literature, that I will be able to apply to my next academic endeavour. In addition, preparing for and conducting research interviews has taught me skills that are transferrable to other interview situations and therefore relevant to my daily work. For a more rounded skillset, I realise that I now need to also develop quantitative research skills. In the future, I would also try and connect more frequently with fellow students.

The next time I embark on a research project and dissertation, I could plan my research schedule in combination with my work schedule more diligently, so I am not facing any surprises.

I could also seek advice from a researcher who is more experienced in working with CAQDAS software so that my next qualitative analysis is more efficient. I could also discuss quantitative research methods with an experienced researcher to help me choose a tried and tested approach when I undertake that type of research. Tackling these areas will help me feel more prepared when facing the next research project.

Studying for my MBA has also rekindled my interest in the topic of leadership and is making me think about studying for a DBA next.

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Appendix 1 Research consent form



Research consent form

Title of research: The relationship between effective team leadership and evolving work models in a small financial services company. A study of Company X.

Researcher: Claudio Mares

I have agreed to participate in this research study. I have had the purposes of the research explained to me. I understand that my participation is fully voluntary, and I may withdraw from the process at any time up to two weeks after the interview. Further, I understand that:

My personal identity will be safeguarded. My participation in the research will be regarded as confidential information, and I will not be quoted other than as an anonymous participant in the research.

The findings of the research will be published as a master's degree dissertation and may also be published in an academic journal or journals.

I permit the researcher to digitally record the interview and I am aware the recorded interview will be transcribed for analytical purposes. The data gathered will be solely used for the purposes of the research, will be securely stored and safeguarded, and will be destroyed on completion of the research.

Name:

Date:

Please confirm your consent by return email.

Brief introduction to the research and the interview

- ☐ Thank participant again for agreeing to take part in the research. State allocated time.
- ☐ Check that signed research consent form still OK, incl. recording of interview. Make sure participant feels comfortable in expressing their views. Confidentiality, data protection.
- ☐ Start recording.
- ☐ Re-present the research topic and research question.
- ☐ Prepare participant for behavioural interviewing. "Think of what has happened during the pandemic and how you dealt with situations and how this may be different to before we moved to virtual teams"
- ☐ Any questions?

Create rapport... e.g., how do you like working here?

Interview guide

General probing/prompts:	
Team leaders Can you please give me an example of a time when you did that? Can you please tell me a little bit more about that? What does that look like for you? On a scale of 1-10 how effective was the way you did / made /...? With the benefit of hindsight, would you have done anything differently? (What effect do you think that would have had?)	Team members: Can you please give me an example of a time when they did that? Can you please tell me a little bit more about that? What does that look like for you? On a scale of 1-10 how effective was the way they did / made /...? With the benefit of hindsight, do you think they could have done anything differently? (What effect do you think that would have had?)

Introductory question

Do you lead a team? If Y > A. if N > B

A. For team leaders

Themes	Stem question	Possible follow-up / probing questions
Team leadership - general	1 What do you regard as the priorities of your role as team leader?	Picking up on answer... how do you make sure you are effective / efficient at so and so...?
		Have your priorities changed since the first lockdown? If so, examples...?
Interactions of team lead	2 How do you tend to work with the people who report to you?	If unclear: for instance: 1-2-1 or team meetings / phone / f2f / text message / when during the day etc.
		Has this changed as the organisation transitioned from face-to-face to virtual working in 2020?
		If yes, how has this changed?
		How did you find the transition?
		Has this changed as the organisation transitioned from virtual to hybrid working?
		If yes, how has this changed?
Communication	3 How have you communicated with your team since the first lockdown?	How did you find the transition?
		Interval? 1-2-1? Whole team?
		Is this a change to pre-pandemic? How?
		Do you engage with the team only via synchronous communication means or also asynchronously?
		What means of communication do you tend to use?

		Specifically in Virtual and Hybrid: how do you make sure everyone is heard?
		Specifically in Virtual and Hybrid: How do you make sure meeting etiquette is established and adhered to?
		Have you encountered any issues with technology? Has your team encountered any issues with technology?
		How have you supported them in such situations?
		How does your team communicate amongst themselves? Do you know?
		Scaling: too little / too much communication?
Clarity of roles / supporting shared mental models	4	How have you matched tasks that needed to be tackled to the skills available within the team?
		Are each team member's role and contributions clear to everyone in the team?
		Is the team's role clear to each team member? Y / N & what is the role?
		Is your team aligned with other teams in the organisation? How have you done that?
		Have you had to add to the team? Examples... Reasons...
		How have you supported knowledge transfer within the team?
Team culture	5	Have you done anything to encourage team members to communicate with each other?
		What makes your team unique?
		How have you contributed to this uniqueness?
		What would someone outside of the team say makes the team unique?

		Social interaction outside work? At work and outside task interaction? How do you describe the team to the outside world? Scaling - how proud are you of your team?
Leadership & Management / Measuring output vs. control of actions	6 How have you measured your team's success during the pandemic?	Has this changed as you transitioned from f2f to virtual to hybrid? How have you supported your team in resolving complex problems? Have you applied the same measure of success for f2f and virtual? Please elaborate. How have you celebrated team / team member success? Do you keep track of everyone's working hours?
Dealing with challenges / (conflict management)	7 What have been the challenges of working virtually?	What has been the biggest one of those challenges? How have you gone about tackling it? (or any that are mentioned) If conflict comes up: How have you supported your team members when they were dealing with conflict amongst themselves? How have you ensured you hear about issues in the team? Has conflict arisen? What tends to trigger conflict?

Boundary of work-life
/ mental health / caring

8 Have you been able to establish a healthy
work/life balance?

How have you done that?

Do you think your team members have been able to do it?

How have you supported your team members? Can you
give an example?

Has this changed as the organisation transitioned from
face-to-face to virtual working in 2020?

If yes, how has this changed?

Has this changed as the organisation transitioned from
virtual to hybrid working?

If yes, how has this changed?

Flexibility considered?

How are you supporting the team in establishing the %
they work in the office vs at home/anywhere?

What advice would you give someone moving into your
role?

B. For team members

Themes	Stem question	Possible follow-up / probing questions
Team leadership - general	1 What do you regard as the priorities of your team leader's role?	Picking up on answer... how have they made sure they are effective / efficient at so and so...? What advice would you give someone moving into your role? Have their priorities changed since the first lockdown? If so, examples...?
Interactions of team lead	2 How does your team leader tend to work with you?	If unclear: for instance: 1-2-1 or team meetings / phone / f2f / text message / when during the day etc. Has this changed as the organisation transitioned from face-to-face to virtual working in 2020? If yes, how has this changed? How did you find the transition? Has this changed as the organisation transitioned from virtual to hybrid working? If yes, how has this changed? How did you find the transition?
Communication	3 How has your team leader communicated with you since the first lockdown?	Interval? 1-2-1? Whole team? Is this a change to pre-pandemic? How? Do they engage with you only via synchronous communication means or also asynchronously?

		What means of communication do they tend to use? Specifically in Virtual and Hybrid: how do they make sure everyone is heard? Specifically in Virtual and Hybrid: How do they make sure meeting etiquette is established and adhered to? Have you encountered any issues with technology? How have they supported you in such situations? How do you communicate with other team members? Is the team leader aware? Scaling: too little / too much communication?
Clarity of roles / supporting shared mental models	4 How has your team leader matched tasks that needed to be tackled to the skills available within the team?	Are each team member's role and contributions clear to everyone in the team? Is the team's role clear to each team member? Y / N & what is the role? Is your team aligned with other teams in the organisation? How has the team leader done that? Have they had to add to the team? How did that make you feel? How have they supported knowledge transfer within the team?
Team culture	5 Has your team leader done anything to encourage you and your colleagues to communicate with each other?	What makes your team unique? How have they contributed to this uniqueness?

			What would someone outside of the team say makes the team unique?
			Social interaction outside work? At work and outside task interaction?
			How do you describe the team to the outside world?
			How do they describe the team to the outside world?
			Scaling - how proud are you of your team?
Leadership & Management / Measuring output vs. control of actions	6	How has your team leader measured the team's success during the pandemic?	Has this changed as you transitioned from f2f to virtual to hybrid?
			How have they supported you in resolving complex problems?
			Have they applied the same measure of success for f2f and virtual? Please elaborate.
			How have they celebrated team / team member success?
			Do they keep track of everyone's working hours?
Dealing with challenges / (conflict management)	7	What have been the challenges of working remotely?	What has been the biggest one of those challenges?
			Has your team leader helped with tackling that challenge? How? (or any that are mentioned)
			What else could they have done?
			If conflict comes up:
			How have they supported you when you were dealing with conflict with other team members?

Boundary of work-life
/ mental health / caring

8 Do you think you have established a healthy
work/life balance?

How have they ensured they hear about issues in the
team?

Has conflict arisen?

What tends to trigger conflict?

Has your team leader helped you to do that?

Can you give an example?

Has this changed as the organisation transitioned from
face-to-face to virtual working in 2020?

If yes, how has this changed?

Has this changed as the organisation transitioned from
virtual to hybrid working?

If yes, how has this changed?

Flexibility taken into account?

How are they supporting you in establishing the % you
work in the office vs at home/anywhere?

Closing the interview

- ☐ Briefly cover research consent form content again.
- ☐ Seek permission for follow-up meeting if required.
- ☐ Any questions?
- ☐ Thank participant again.
- ☐ End recording.

Post-interview notes

- ☐ How did the interview go? Did the conversation flow? Rapport?
- ☐ Recording OK for transcript? Quality of recording?
- ☐ Are themes emerging that I did not foresee? Topics to review in future interviews?

Appendix 3 Application for ethical approval [Editor's note – the ethical approval forms changed in 2022]

09/07/2021 RKC OnlineCampus - Thesis Repository Application for ethical approval University approval status: APPROVED RESEARCH ETHICS FORM Title of research: The relationship between effective team leadership and evolving work models in a small financial services company. A study of Company X. Please indicate whether any of the below apply to you: ☒ Research involving living human participants, their tissue or their data. If you interview or survey people, this must be ticked. ☐ Research with the potential for adverse environmental impact. ☐ Research involving NHS patients, staff or resources. ☐ Scientific and medical research involving animals. PROVIDE AN OUTLINE OF THE PROJECT Everyone must complete this brief outline. This information communicates to those who are asked to approve the research what the project entails. Where will you get your research material? Documents: ☒ Unpublished ☒ Published ☐ Existing databases ☐ Other: Online or social media: ☐ Blogs ☐ Chat rooms ☒ Webpages https://campus.college.ch/thesis_repository/preview_ethical_approval/852 1/6	09/07/2021 RKC OnlineCampus - Thesis Repository Other: From people by: ☒ Interviews ☐ Focus groups ☐ Questionnaires ☐ Other: Biological, medical or social data from: ☐ Animals ☐ Members of the public ☐ Medical patients ☐ Social care patients Other research material: If human participants are involved are they: ☐ Under 16 ☒ Adults able to give consent ☐ Adults unable to give consent Briefly describe your project All fields in this section are required. Outline: Through my research I would like to understand what makes for effective team leadership during the evolution from office based to virtual to hybrid working in a small financial services company. Aims: I will analyse information gathered through interviews to identify what constitutes effective leadership in office based, virtual, and hybrid work models. I would like to find out if there are differences in what competencies are essential depending on the work model. Recommend actions that could be taken to maximise the positive attributes of team leadership across all three scenarios with a focus on the hybrid work mode, while limiting the negative influencing factors. Methods: Primary data collection through qualitative analysis. I am planning to interview 8-10 staff and long-term contractors of the organisation. This represents approx. 53-66% of the whole population. I will be interviewing leaders and followers to try and obtain a balanced view on the research topics. Maybe collection of secondary data: HR staff satisfaction questionnaires relating to working in the various work modes as the company progresses through the stages. (I have classified this as unpublished documents above) https://campus.college.ch/thesis_repository/preview_ethical_approval/852 2/6
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09/07/2021 RKC OnlineCampus - Thesis Repository Identified ethical issues: (Specify whether any pose more than minimal risk) Welfare: In my research I will be concerned to safeguard the welfare of any participants, and I will not put anyone at risk. I would classify this as posing minimal risk. Informed consent: The potential participants in my research will be invited via an email containing a brief description of the project, what is expected by the potential participants, and how much of their time will be taken up. The email will also include the research consent form I have prepared. Once a potential participant has agreed to be interviewed as part of my research, I will schedule a Zoom interview with them. I would classify this as posing minimal risk. Confidentiality: I will anonymise data that I collect as part of my research by allocating a number code to each interviewee. In any transcripts I create, I will also anonymise any job titles, department names or any other data that may make the interviewee recognisable. All recorded data and transcripts relating to the interviewees will be saved only against these allocated number codes in my personal OneDrive folders. Any information linking respondents' names to these codes will be safely stored separately in my Google drive folders. I would classify this as posing minimal risk. Data protection: The research data will be collected fairly and lawfully, will be accurate, will be stored securely in my cloud based personal OneDrive and Google Drive data storage systems as recordings of the interviews, as transcripts, and interviewee number code referencing, and will only be held for as long as necessary. Data will be processed within the research participants' rights, under the terms it was collected and be relevant, adequate, and not excessive. I will be the only person with direct access to the data. I will share some of the transcript data with my dissertation supervisor during the presentation of findings phase of my research. I would classify this as posing minimal risk. INITIAL SCREENING CHECKLIST Please complete the initial screening checklist by clicking either 'Yes' or 'No' in each row: Subject area If the research involves matters of social, political or personal sensitivity you need to be aware of the boundary between legitimate academic enquiry and unnecessarily offensive or illegal behaviour. 1. Will the research require the collection of primary source material that might possibly be seen as offensive or considered illegal to access or hold on a computer? Examples might be studies related to state security, pornography, abuse or terrorism. Check the Prevent Duty Guidance for Higher Education. OR Does your research concern groups which may be construed as terrorist or extremist? https://campus.college.ch/thesis_repository/preview_ethical_approval/952 3/6	09/07/2021 RKC OnlineCampus - Thesis Repository If your answer to this question is "Yes", you must complete and submit the supplementary form available as an appendix to your Research Ethics approval form. You will also need to complete Appendices A and B at the end of the form to ensure secure data storage for security-sensitive information. • NO 2. Will the study involve discussion or disclosure of information about sensitive topics? This may involve legal issues that are nonetheless sensitive (e.g. sexual orientation, or states of health), or topics where illegal behaviour could be revealed (e.g. abuse, criminal activity, under-age drinking or sexual activity). • NO Participants: recruiting and consent If the research involves collecting data from people you need to be aware of issues related to ensuring that they are able to give informed consent to participate where appropriate. This means being aware of how people are recruited, and whether they understand what information is being collected and why. In some cases data collection has to be covert, or informed consent is not possible from the participants themselves. These require particular attention. 3. Will the study require the co-operation of a gatekeeper to give access to, or to help recruit, participants? Examples include head teachers giving access to schools, ministers giving access to congregations, group leaders publicising your research. • NO 4. Will it be necessary for participants to take part in the study without their knowledge or consent at the time? Examples might be studies of group behaviour or the use of data that was not intentionally collected for research. • NO 5. Will the study involve recruitment of patients through the NHS? There are particular issues and procedures required if the research will involve NHS users. • NO 6. Will inducements be offered to participants? This could include direct payments, the offer of being entered in a prize draw, or, for students, the offer of course credit for participation. It does not include the payment of legitimate expenses. • NO 7. Does the study involve participants who are particularly vulnerable or unable to give informed consent? You must answer 'yes' if any participants are under 18. Adults with learning disabilities, the frail elderly, or anyone who may be easily coerced due to lack of capacity is considered vulnerable. If you teach and you wish to research https://campus.college.ch/thesis_repository/preview_ethical_approval/952 4/6
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09/07/2021 RKC OnlineCampus - Thesis Repository your own students, they should be classed as potentially vulnerable. • NO Data collection Where the collection of data involves more than trivial risk to participants researchers must weigh carefully the necessity of the procedure, the level of possible harm, and the benefits of the research. 8. Will the study require participants to commit extensive time to the study? Single session interviews or completing questionnaires once or twice would not be considered excessive, but long term studies with multiple sampling, intensive data gathering over a day or more, or long interviews and questionnaires that take some hours to complete might fall into this category. • NO 9. Are drugs, placebos or any other substances to be administered to participants, or will the study involve invasive, intrusive or potentially harmful procedures of any kind? Even simple procedures such as tasting sessions might be dangerous if participants have allergies, so tick yes if the research involves any substance trials. • NO 10. If there are experimental and control groups, will being in one group disadvantage participants? Examples might be testing new teaching methods where pupils without the trial procedure may be disadvantaged, or trying a new procedure where the outcomes are uncertain. • NO 11. Is an extensive degree of exercise or physical exertion involved? If participants are unused to such exercise it could put them at risk, so it is important for researchers to be aware of this and communicate it to volunteers. • NO 12. Will blood or tissue samples be obtained from participants? These procedures require specialist training and are covered by particular ethical codes. • NO 13. Is pain or more than mild physical discomfort likely to result from the study? • NO 14. Could the study induce psychological stress or anxiety or cause harm or negative consequences beyond the risks encountered in normal life? This might be because the subject area is sensitive, the nature of task (e.g. decision-making under pressure), or the participants are particularly vulnerable to stress or anxiety (e.g. those with a history of poor mental health). https://campus.college.ch/thesis_repository/preview_ethical_approval/852 5/6	09/07/2021 RKC OnlineCampus - Thesis Repository • NO ROUTE: 2 (MORE INFO) COMMENTS TO STUDENT 08.07.2021 10:06 by your supervisor: This now looks fine George Boak https://campus.college.ch/thesis_repository/preview_ethical_approval/852 6/6
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Appendix 4 Initial level 1 coding of interviews

Initial Codes, in alphabetical order	Found in this many interviews
GT. adapt frequency of communication to team member's needs	1
GT. address issues as they arise	1
GT. adjust how they engage with team members depending on team member preferences	1
GT. allocate tasks to people with the right skillset	3
GT. allow for flexibility in work hours in the day	2
GT. approachable for a chat	1
GT. approachable to discuss any problem	1
GT. assign tasks to person with best fitting skillset	1
GT. be a focal point that coordinates teamwork	1
GT. be a leadership figure bringing team together	1
GT. be a role model	1
GT. be hands-on and do the work	1
GT. be prepared to do tasks that seem outside of the scope of your role	1
GT. being a sounding board for ideas	1
GT. being accessible	1
GT. being accessible, kind, decent, fair	1
GT. being approachable	2
GT. being approachable to help solve problems	1
GT. being approachable for advice	1
GT. being directive on how certain tasks need to be completed	2
GT. being respectful of each other's time and sticking to scheduled meeting time	1
GT. bring together quite different characters	1
GT. bringing people together	1
GT. build trust with team members	1
GT. cares for well-being of staff	1
GT. celebrate success by being positive	2
GT. celebrate success by giving public praise and recognition	1
GT. celebrate success by providing positive written feedback	1
GT. celebrate success by saying thank you	1
GT. celebrate success with present and kind message	1
GT. celebrate team member success by paying a bonus	1
GT. celebrate team member's success by acknowledging in wider team scenario	1
GT. change in roles, lack of clarity	1
GT. check in to see how team members are doing	1
GT. clarity in roles within team	3
GT. coaching	2
GT. collaborate on tasks. small team	1
GT. collaborate with other teams	1
GT. collaborate with team member on team's tasks	1
GT. collaborate with the team	3
GT. communicate clearly on tasks and priorities	1
GT. communicate openly and frankly on issues arising in delivery tasks	1
GT. communicate regularly to ensure team aligned with organisation	2
GT. communicate regularly to keep team members up to speed with work that is going on in the team	1
GT. communicate with other teams when there is an issue	2
GT. communicate with team member regularly on work and social aspects	1
GT. communicate regularly to align tasks within team	2
GT. communication with team good, open door	1

GT. consult with experts and come to a common decision	1
GT. consult with experts and then make decision by themselves	1
GT. create new role to bridge gap between teams for better alignment	1
GT. create opportunity for training	3
GT. daily catch-ups to understand what everyone in team is working on	1
GT. dealing with conflict by discussion	1
GT. decisions to be made at all levels of organisation, level structure	1
GT. delegate tasks to people with right skillset	2
GT. delegate tasks to people with right skillset and role	2
GT. deliver for the business	1
GT. deliver on tasks with lean team	1
GT. different personalities in team biggest challenge to manage	1
GT. distribute workload within team	1
GT. drive innovation	1
GT. encourage collaboration through assigning tasks to more than one team member	1
GT. encourage communication between teams to strengthen alignment	1
GT. encourage team members to connect with employees in other team for better alignment	2
GT. engage with team member on ad-hoc basis when needed	1
GT. engage with team members on one-to-one basis, no team meetings	1
GT. engaged to understand employee and personal well-being	1
GT. establish what skillset team members have	1
GT. facilitate team processes	1
GT. feedback from stakeholders on team members' performance	1
GT. financial incentives to help motivation	1
GT. focused on tasks, not interested in non-work chat	1
GT. get on well with team members	1
GT. good understanding of communication within the team	1
GT. good understanding of how team member operates	1
GT. guidance to team members on what tasks to tackle	1
GT. hands-off	1
GT. hands-off leadership provides self-motivation to help people out and do things	1
GT. help establish work life balance	1
GT. help overcome challenges with open door policy	1
GT. hold weekly company-wide meeting to inform everyone about what is going on	1
GT. if person does not pull their way, let them go	1
GT. innovation as sign of business performing well	1
GT. keep external stakeholders happy and delivery quality work	1
GT. keep in touch with external parties to make sure Company X is aligned	1
GT. keep positive team dynamic	1
GT. keep team focused on overall direct of the organisation	1
GT. keep team moving forward but lack of communicating vision	1
GT. keep team's skillset current to match tasks, add expertise when needed	2
GT. keep the ship stable	1
GT. keep their boss happy	1
GT. KPIs based on skillset	1
GT. lack of buy-in due to decision being taken without consulting wider team	1
GT. lack of communicating vision	1
GT. lack of communication to link Company X's strategy to everyone's jobs	1
GT. lack of consultation with area expert on a topic	1
GT. lack of executive team to discuss longer terms issues and strategy	1
GT. lack of leadership team involvement in decision making results in lack of buy-in	1
GT. lack of pyramid structure. NEG	1
GT. lack of social interactions in company	1
GT. lack of support when dealing with complex problems	1
GT. lack visibility of link between personal goals and business goals	1
GT. lead and guide the team	1
GT. lead by example	1
GT. lead by example in clear separate of work and personal life	2

GT. lead by example in providing safe space to work (no discrimination)	1
GT. lead team in one direction	1
GT. let people get on with their work	4
GT. let team members work on their tasks collaboratively	2
GT. level of communication with team member varies	1
GT. line management of staff	1
GT. look after their staff	1
GT. looking after team members' well-being	1
GT. maintain morale of team by being accommodating	1
GT. make sure team meets financial objectives	1
GT. make sure team's and team member's KPIs are met	1
GT. make team member feel like they can ask for help, support if needed	1
GT. making sure team members are engaged	1
GT. making sure team members communicate amongst themselves on technical issues	1
GT. making sure team members enjoy working for them	1
GT. making sure team members feel like they can approach team leader, open door	1
GT. making sure team members feel rewarded for their contributions	1
GT. making sure team processes and structure are in place	1
GT. making sure workload distributed evenly so staff are not demoralised	1
GT. manage admin side of things, such as holidays	1
GT. manage external relationships	1
GT. match skills in team with tasks at hand	3
GT. measure success on individual basis	1
GT. measure effectiveness of team by making few mistakes	1
GT. measure of success = team leader's boss is happy	1
GT. measure success through monitoring of accurate team tasks delivery	2
GT. measure team success via individual goal.	3
GT. measure team's success by how well the organisation continues to operate	1
GT. measuring team member success through appraisals.	1
GT. measuring team success by way of level of collaboration on shared tasks with other teams	1
GT. measuring team success through positive or negative feedback from stakeholders	1
GT. meeting etiquette - open to discuss anything	1
GT. meeting often informal	1
GT. mentor direct reports by preparing for client meetings	1
GT. mentoring	2
GT. monitor that work gets done	1
GT. no measures for team-wide success or failure	1
GT. no scheduled team meetings	2
GT. non-directive leadership	1
GT. not encouraging social interaction of whole team	1
GT. not forcing people to interact outside of work if they do not want to do so	1
GT. not keen on delegating, get on with own work	1
GT. not sufficient social interaction, communication	1
GT. offer support to help when team member overwhelmed	1
GT. only collaborate with team member when there is an issue	1
GT. open communication of any topic	1
GT. opposite of pyramid structure, level structure	1
GT. organising the team	1
GT. paternalistic leadership style, concerned with well-being of staff	1
GT. point out that diverse viewpoints produce better results	1
GT. protect and promote team externally	1
GT. protect team against work overload imposed by others	1
GT. protect team publicly when criticised	1
GT. protect the team from different aspects	1
GT. provide clarity in roles	5
GT. provide context to tasks and help prioritize	1
GT. provide guidance when needed	2
GT. provide safe space to work, no discrimination	1

GT. providing training	2
GT. put tasks into wider context	1
GT. redefine roles of staff during pandemic to support new needs of the business	1
GT. regular communication with team members	1
GT. regular one-to-one meetings to review year's goals and track progress	1
GT. rely on external expert advice when required	1
GT. scheduled, structured meetings	2
GT. set strategy of the company	1
GT. set vision	1
GT. share tasks with team member	1
GT. share tasks with team members in collaborative way	1
GT. sort issues within team, act as one team externally	1
GT. success means fewer errors	1
GT. support team member by providing contacts needed for a task	1
GT. support team member in difficult tasks	2
GT. support the team member when dealing with challenges	2
GT. supporting team members in their projects	1
GT. supportive of team member's ideas	1
GT. team aligned with Company goals	2
GT. team business plan sets out individual contributions to be made	1
GT. team leader feels part of the team	1
GT. team meetings have an agenda allowing for everyone to prepare and contribute	1
GT. team member to solve own problems	1
GT. team member unaware of how team success is measured	1
GT. team members pull together	1
GT. team not aligned with other teams in the company	1
GT. team success is not celebrated	1
GT. trust people to use flexible times and get job done	1
GT. trust staff to get their work done	1
GT. trust team member to get on with their work	3
GT. trusts team member to make important decisions	1
GT. trying to encourage communication amongst team members	1
GT. understand the team members	2
GT. value different opinions	1
GT. value team member contributions	1
GT. work processes to foster collaboration and training opportunity, mentoring	1
GT. work with consultants if skillset in team missing	1
HT. allow for flexibility in work patterns	1
HT. allow for personal interaction, chat in addition to exchange on tasks	2
HT. allows team member to flex work hours and days	2
HT. build up topics to discuss face to face when in office instead of virtually	1
HT. collaborate on personal level with team members	1
HT. communicate more freely on all topics allowing for more information exchange	1
HT. communication - how	1
HT. coordinate for collaboration face to face in office	2
HT. Create a hybrid solution that works for staff	1
HT. encourage team to be in office together for social interaction	1
HT. encourage team to be in the office on same days to collaborate	1
HT. flexibility in start and finish time allows for better work life balance	2
HT. flexibility of work hours enables staff to work more effectively	1
HT. flexibility of days in office to allow for collaboration in office	1
HT. flexible work pattern invaluable	2
HT. have a glass of wine together outside office	2
HT. include staff ideas on how hybrid working at Company X should look like	1
HT. include staff input into new hybrid work mode	1
HT. informal knowledge sharing easier	2
HT. interacting in office helps make sense of how tasks within teams work together	1
HT. lack of coordinating collaborative vs solitary tasks	1

HT. lack of coordination for social interaction	1
HT. lack of coordination of office days	1
HT. lack of coordination to flexible arrangements	1
HT. lack of social communication in office	1
HT. lack of social interaction with people in the office	1
HT. lead by example in making use of flexible working hours	1
HT. less flexibility throughout the day when back in the office full day	1
HT. less formal meetings happen in the office, body language gets picked up	1
HT. let team member work on solitary tasks when at home	1
HT. maybe need to adjust core hours to make sure sufficient time for collaboration is available	1
HT. measuring success	1
HT. mentoring in hybrid team	1
HT. plan office days for collaborative tasks	2
HT. plan week with collaboration in office, solitary tasks at home	1
HT. promote flexible work hours and allow team members to work on that basis	1
HT. review core hours again as people get more comfortable with living with Covid-19	1
HT. run through things with team member and provide instant feedback and support	1
HT. seemingly less important topics get discussed vs VT	1
HT. social interaction in office really appreciated	2
HT. team leader accommodating flexible work patterns in day	1
HT. team leader allowing flexible start and finish to alleviate concerns over commuting	1
HT. team leader does not engage in chatting in office	1
HT. team leader has not clearly communicated why team goes back to the office	1
HT. team leader lacks support of flexible working hours	1
HT. team leader not actively helping with adjusting back to office environment	1
HT. team leader not supportive of hybrid mode	1
HT. team member needs team leader to coordinate office days	1
HT. try and use office days to collaborate	1
VT. communication to motivate team member	1
VT. meeting etiquette better than in f2f	1
VT. structured introduction week to the organisation	1
VT. asking for input from others on complex work lacked	1
VT. asynchronous communication benefits. quick questions	1
VT. asynchronous communication	5
VT. blurred line between work and personal life	1
VT. communicate more formally on tasks, less chatting	1
VT. communicate on ad-hoc basis	1
VT. communicate regularly to keep the glue together	1
VT. communicate regularly with team member	1
VT. communicate regularly with team members	4
VT. communicating with all staff easier virtually	1
VT. communicating with team member only when they need to	1
VT. communication easier as cannot be overheard by others	1
VT. communication is more formatted, structured, planned	1
VT. communication is more structured virtually	1
VT. communication more focussed virtually	1
VT. concerned with staff's mental well-being during lockdown, social interactions	1
VT. does not get involved in helping team member sort IT issues	1
VT. encourage communication amongst team members on specific tasks only	1
VT. encourage open-door policy, available to support, approachable	1
VT. encourage social interactions virtually	2
VT. encourage team members to share and contribute in team meetings	1
VT. establish way of working that allows for regular communication	1
VT. focus on own work, lack of checking in with team members	1
VT. group topics before interacting	1
VT. grouping topics to discuss into one meeting helps reducing interruptions	1
VT. help people get used to new way of communicating virtually	1
VT. help work life balance by providing flexibility in work hours	1

VT. hiring staff in virtual mode and fully integrate them is difficult	1
VT. IT support is there if issues arise	2
VT. keep communication to minimum to get on with work	1
VT. lack of casual interaction	1
VT. lack of checking in to see how team member was doing during initial lockdown	1
VT. lack of communication during lockdowns big challenge	1
VT. lack of communication fuelled anxiety; isolation	1
VT. lack of discussion about work life balance of team members	1
VT. lack of encouraging informal communication	1
VT. lack of hands-on monitoring opportunity	1
VT. lack of meaningful communication and lack of communication with external stakeholders	1
VT. lack of opportunity for broader discussions and lack of alignment	1
VT. lack of opportunity for informal quick chats to check in	1
VT. lack of opportunity for teams gel together	1
VT. less communication than when co-located	1
VT. let team member sort IT issues for themselves	1
VT. make sure communication is structured	2
VT. make sure everyone gets a change to speak in meetings	1
VT. make sure everyone is heard in a meeting	1
VT. make sure team feels connected even though team members are working remotely	1
VT. making sure team has required IT support	1
VT. making sure the team communicates when working from home	1
VT. measuring success	1
VT. meetings need to be planned for collaboration	1
VT. mentoring virtually	1
VT. missed interaction, being around people	1
VT. not encouraging social communication between team members	1
VT. not picking up finer details of how someone is doing	1
VT. organise virtual social gatherings to make everyone feel connected still	1
VT. provide technology solution that enables team member to work effectively	1
VT. regular contact to check in on how team members are doing	2
VT. relate to team member's issues, make them feel like they are not alone in the situation	1
VT. set an example by participating in weekly social Zoom calls	1
VT. share best practices for V meeting etiquette	1
VT. social team calls feel forced but recognise benefit	1
VT. stick with own preference for communication platform	1
VT. synchronous communication	8
VT. team leader does not expect more hours to be worked due to lack of commute	1
VT. team leader set up social team calls	1
VT. team member did not feel like they could reach out to express anxiety issues	1
VT. technology improves communication as more focused	1
VT. trust people to do their jobs remotely	1
VT. using communication technology to check people are not working too late	1
VT. very little communication	1
VT. work life balance better working from home	1
X. Company X's leadership team pulls together	1
X. Company X's leadership team, lack of	2
X. lack of face-to-face meetings when lockdown restrictions were loosened	1
X. measuring success has changed	1
X. more relaxed, less directive during pandemic compared to before	1
X. more relaxed, more headspace to think of thanking staff for good work	1
X. no change in how individual goals are measured	7
X. no change in leadership style during pandemic	2
X. team leader does not see need to go back into the office.	1
X. team leader's priorities have not changed during pandemic	5

Appendix 5 Level 2 themes - interview coding

Level 2 Theme	Level 2 Sub-Theme (if applicable)	Found in this many interviews
Advocating flexibility of work patterns (HT)		9
	Flexibility in start and finish time allows for better work life balance	
	Flexible working hours	
	Include staff input into hybrid mode structure	
	In-office days for social interaction	
	Optimise work for collaboration in office, solitary work elsewhere	
Aligning team's work with wider organisational context		6
Being a role model		4
Being approachable		7
Being concerned with well-being of staff		8
Being protective of team to outside world		2
Celebrating success		7
Collaborating with team members		7
Communication, key to success		10
	Communication in office less structured (HT)	
	Communicate clearly on tasks, processes	
	Communicate with team members regularly to make sure team aligned (VT)	
	Communication is structured, planned (VT)	
	Encourage active participation of team members in calls	

	Encourage communication amongst the team members	
	Establish frequency of communication	
	Meeting etiquette (VT mainly)	
	Social interaction through team calls (VT)	
	Synchronous and asynchronous communication channels (VT)	
	Use of communication channels to check on staff's well-being	
Developing team members		6
	Developing team members (GT)	
	Developing team members (HT)	
	Developing team members (VT)	
Encouraging collaboration with other teams		3
Ensuring the right skillset is available		9
Informal and social interaction in office environment (HT)		4
IT support available to work effectively in new circumstances		4
Measuring success		9
	Individual team member success measures	
	Teamwide success measures	
Mechanism in place to deal with conflict when it arises		2
Providing clarity of roles		7
Setting direction, ensuring team delivers, and keeping external stakeholders happy		6
Structuring and monitoring team and processes		6
Supporting diverse ideas and viewpoints		2
Supporting innovative ways of working		3
Supporting team members so they can work efficiently		5

Trusting people to get on with their work	7
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Additional grouping of codes:

zz. Some Longitudinal aspect	8
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Appendix 6 Level 3 themes - quotes from the interviews

Level 3 theme	Quotes
Caring about people	I.1: "I don't think there was any expectation for it to become like that from my team leader ... I don't think they expected me to work from eight to six every day."
	I.2: "So it's important for me to have that time just to talk about how things are going."
	I.2: "Maintaining the morale of the team by being very accommodating."
	I.3: "So I constantly emphasise the fact that when you're at work you're at work, but when you're on holiday, you're on holiday. You shouldn't be getting disturbed."
	I.4: "Yeah, I mean, so that's, you know, making sure that I'm not getting too stressed over it all. Yeah, so they are good at that."
	I.5: "Make sure that my team actually enjoy working for me."
	I.7: "And they have got quite a paternalistic style. You know, our well-being is important."
	I.9: "It's important to give people a safe place to work where there is no discrimination of any sort, and that's really important to me."
Collaborating with the team	I.1: "I knew that they would help me make to make a decision. And I felt we made the right decision between us."
	I.5: "Don't worry about interrupting me or don't worry about anything like that. Just call me and let me know."
	I.7: "They are very, very accessible. So, I would feel able to talk to them about things."
	I.9: "And that's important that I make them feel that they can communicate with me and be honest with me and say if they think that something's wrong. So, you know, that sort of idea of an open door."
	I.9: "Making sure we're all helping each other."

Communication, key to success

I.10: "But we double check with each other on areas that we are less familiar with. And, you know, it is a genuine discussion. Have you seen this before or have you heard of this?"

I.4: "The only time we ever really collaborate, if you like, is when there is an issue."

I.2: "My team leader kept in contact with me to make sure I didn't just drift away in what was a really uncertain, difficult time for me..."

I.8: "Just kept in touch, you know, initially three or four times a day..."

I.8: "They contacted me, so there was always a link, a communication of some description... and that really helped..."

I.1: "The difference with being in the office where you can just call on someone who is at the other end of the office or beside you in the office."

I.5: "I find that on Zoom and MS Teams calls, people tend not to talk over one another actually quite as frequently as they might do if they were in a room together."

I.8: "In the virtual mode, that has meant that I've had to book time with them so that we can discuss those things."

I.9: "It [communication] has probably become a little bit more structured working from home."

I.6: "If there's something that's a bit on the periphery that it might not be mentioned in a virtual call, whereas actually, if you're in the same room, people will kind of go..."

I.6: "People speaking more openly and, you know, giving more information because we're in the office."

I.5: "I make sure that I'm catching up with both of them a couple of times a week."

I.9: "I have very regular conversations with my direct reports."

I.8: "Just kept in touch, you know, initially three or four times a day, and that kind of reduced over time as when the need required."

I.2: "Regular communication and keeping us informed in team meetings about the progress of the project."

	I.3: “We have daily, more or less daily conversations on the telephone.” I.6: “MS Teams mostly when we’re outside the office, and I would probably say more so than email.” I.1: “They’ll instant message me.” I.2: “Again, instant messaging like teams, WhatsApp and video conferencing. So again, MS teams.” I.4: “It’s just anxiety. I don’t feel like that now, but I think initially, just because there was a lack of communication.”
Developing team members	I.2: “It’s important to for me to have someone to learn from and to gain experience from. And that’s my team leader’s role.” I.2: “For example, making sure I know the importance of educate myself about the wider industry.” I.2: “Stayed engaged with the team and made sure there’s always learning opportunities available in the virtual environment.” I5: “Instead of me kind of critiquing it after they had done it and kind of making them feel as if what they were doing was always wrong, I thought what we would do is we would just get together on a call like this, open up the screen between us and begin to work through...” I.6: “Specifically involving me in things that probably are outside of my role... broadening my knowledge of the company or being involved with them...”
Encouraging social interactions	I.4: “I did feel very isolated... when it was announced that we were going to go back to the office two days a week, I was actually over the moon.” I.6: “You realize how much easier it is to have someone sat next to you as sounding board, or have someone to, you know, your manager sitting next to you to run, run through things.” I.6: “From a meeting point of view, collaboration is different in face-to-face because I think you actually have more time to kind of get to know each other as people.” I.8: “It’s just a bit more social when we’re in the office together.”

	I.9: “I’ve really enjoyed going back... you’re picking up body language.” I.7: “But they’ve got their headphones and taking phone calls and sometimes if you say something to them, you kind of feel like you’re interrupting.”
Flexibility of hybrid working	I.1: “The flexible hours have been really good in terms of allowing us to travel at a time we feel more or less comfortable.” I.2: “If there’s a member of the team that, you know, needs to work from home for a day because they’ve got contractors coming in because they’ve just moved flat.” I.2: “We structure the week so that most of the meetings are on two or three days. I don’t feel under pressure to come into the office.” I.4: “They are very flexible in that way... they don’t expect me to be sat here all day long.” I.6: “Encouraging people to be in the office together.” I.9: “That flexibility was put in place as well because of concerns over people traveling on trains.” I.9: “I can give people more flexibility and they can still do their jobs as effectively as they used to do or even more effectively as they used to do pre-pandemic then that’s fantastic.” I.10: “As long as I am available across the week for the number of hours that I’m supposed to work, it doesn’t matter too much when I actually do it, as long as the work gets done.” I.4: “We should really try and coordinate the fact that we’re both in on the same day. But that hasn’t yet occurred.” I.3: “I’ve been working at home now for however long... I don’t particularly want to go into the office. I don’t see the point.”
Keeping team focused on goals and success	I.1: “Just making sure everything was done.” L1: “They sent me a really nice message saying thank you very much and well done.” I.2: “The team leader congratulated me on passing my exam.”

	I.2: “They’re a role model for how everyone in the company should conduct themselves in terms of their enthusiasm and the effort they apply to their role.” I.2: “Things like making sure we hit our targets, meet our deadlines, that hasn’t changed.” I.6: “A real effort is made to specifically include people’s names to show what they’re doing.” I.7: “Success has been measured on an individual basis.” I.8: “They’re very quick to say thank you.” I.9: “Leading by example.” I.10: “It goes back to the plan. Have we done the tasks in the plan that we were expecting to do?” I.7: “I don’t think Company X has ever been particularly strong at communicating or getting anyone to understand the clear path forward.”
Providing structure	I1: “Everybody has a clear place within their team.” I.2: “Organising the team.” I.2: “We have a very clear list of team responsibilities.” I.2: “The tasks are assigned to the most suitable individuals.” I.2: “They took the opportunity to hire someone with different expertise, a different background, and a slightly different role to support us with our tasks.” I.3: “My responsibility as a leader is to ensure that the workloads are OK, consistent.” I.3: “[Dealing with conflict] partly by discussion, you know, coming together and discussing the issue both as a team and individuals and partly by looking for support for myself.” I.3: “Be open and upfront and have these meetings where we can discuss whatever the issue is.” I.5: “If it’s the case that something doesn’t go quite right, you take that as a team.” I.6: “Making sure things like team meetings happen.”

I.6: “Everyone has kind of quite defined roles.”

I.6: “A full week of introduction that my team leader organised.”

I.6: “They’re quite good at kind of looking at a task and delegating to certain people... It’s quite structured in that we have a structured list to say whose responsibility is for what, but also kind of when ad hoc things come up.”

I.7: “They’ll bring in the relevant people. They’ll talk about it. They’ll make a decision. It will happen.”

I.10: “Knowing when it’s appropriate to go outside the firm to get external professional advice.”

I.4: “No, we don’t [have team meetings].”

I.1: “But, you know, usually they will say to me, you know, can you go and think about what we’re going to do? And they will always support my ideas.”

I.1: “They let me get on with my work.”

I.1: “They tend to give me guidance if I need it.”

I.2: “Drive the innovative actions we take.”

I.2: “When we have a new initiative or a new innovation that we’re trying to carry out, I think everyone tends to know what we are looking to get out of it. And that comes from my team leader’s guidance.”

Support team to be as effective as possible

I.2: “My team leader has been important in making sure that although we’re extremely different characters and personalities and we all tend to have very different approaches to our job to make sure that we always work together, collaborate and brings us together. In that sense, I feel like as a team.”

I.3: “Take a big picture and point out to people that we are all different. We do bring different things to the party, and we would work better for that.”

I.4: “So they just trust me to get on with whatever it is I need to get on with.”

I.6: “They’re quite good at kind of looking at a task and delegating to certain people... It’s quite structured in that we have a structured list to say whose responsibility is for what, but also kind of when ad hoc things come up.”

I.6: “It’s quite a diverse range of people. Everyone’s different, everyone comes from a different business background... and the team leader joins those points of view together and you have a really great solution”

I.7: “There’s a level of trust where they know that I’ll do what I can and I’ll get stuff done.”

I.7: “A whole load of stuff that’s happened... set up new subsidiary... new computer system... the team leader has been really good at keeping Company X moving.”

I.8: “They’ve trusted me to research and progress with those without touching base every day.”

I.8: “They’ve been really useful in kind of pointing me in the right direction when I’ve needed help and guidance.”

I.9: “Judging at this time, who’s the best person to deal with that.”

I.9: “Because of the fact they couldn’t travel and do their jobs in the way that they’d done before, we were able to get them sort of repurposed to an extent.”

I.9: “We get lots of evidence of that through the fact that we do new things.”

I.3: “I think the difficulty is because we got different personalities and we work in different ways.”

Team alignment with
outside world

I.2: “The other teams do really just sort of have to follow, you know, the direction we’re going, so I feel like no team could be more aligned than ours.”

I.3: “One of the priorities is to protect the team, as I’ve been saying, from different aspects.”

I.3: “There’s one that’s ongoing at the moment... colleague A came in with a request for support from my team.... We’ve got one on sick. We’ve got me going on holiday. So I’ve had to direct that work to team member B, and they’re not happy with that... So that’s an example of trying to protect.”

I.4: “Whatever the goals Company X has, that’s the purpose... we all need to aim towards the goals of the company.”

I.5: “Some of those mistakes have been escalated on some levels beyond, I think, the level of their importance. But that’s the environment in which we work. So I think dampening that down, making sure that the piece of it goes quiet is one measure of the effectiveness.”

I.8: “I’ve consulted with different areas as well, just to make sure that what I’m writing reflects reality ... So, yes, I think we are aligned with the other areas of the company.”

I.5: “I think this alignment between the teams is probably one of the things that I think may have suffered a little bit with us all sitting at home.”